

A decorative border with intricate floral and scrollwork patterns, rendered in a dark green color, framing the entire page.

BibInVs MN 07

Judges

*Bible Translation:
Interverse MSG/NIV - 7*

God

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Interversed Message/NIV Bible

Judges

Judges 1

MSG

NIV

- 1 A time came after the death of Joshua when the People of Israel asked GOD, "Who will take the lead in going up against the Canaanites to fight them?"
- 1 After the death of Joshua, the Israelites asked the LORD, "Who will be the first to go up and fight for us against the Canaanites?"
- 2 And GOD said, "Judah will go. I've given the land to him."
- 2 The LORD answered, "Judah is to go; I have given the land into their hands."
- 3 The men of Judah said to those of their brother Simeon, "Go up with us to our territory and we'll fight the Canaanites. Then we'll go with you to your territory." And Simeon went with them.
- 3 Then the men of Judah said to the Simeonites their brothers, "Come up with us into the territory allotted to us, to fight against the Canaanites. We in turn will go with you into yours." So the Simeonites went with them.
- 4 So Judah went up. GOD gave them the Canaanites and the Perizzites. They defeated them at Bezek--ten military units!
- 4 When Judah attacked, the LORD gave the Canaanites and Perizzites into their hands and they struck down ten thousand men at Bezek.
- 5 They caught up with My-Master-Bezek there and fought him. They smashed the Canaanites and the Perizzites.
- 5 It was there that they found Adoni-Bezek and fought against him, putting to rout the Canaanites and Perizzites.
- 6 My-Master-Bezek ran, but they gave chase and caught him. They cut off his thumbs and big toes.
- 6 Adoni-Bezek fled, but they chased him and caught him, and cut off his thumbs and big toes.

- 7 My-Master-Bezek said, "Seventy kings with their thumbs and big toes cut off used to crawl under my table, scavenging. Now God has done to me what I did to them." They brought him to Jerusalem and he died there.
- 7 Then Adoni-Bezek said, "Seventy kings with their thumbs and big toes cut off have picked up scraps under my table. Now God has paid me back for what I did to them." They brought him to Jerusalem, and he died there.
- 8 The people of Judah attacked and captured Jerusalem, subduing the city by sword and then sending it up in flames.
- 8 The men of Judah attacked Jerusalem also and took it. They put the city to the sword and set it on fire.
- 9 After that they had gone down to fight the Canaanites who were living in the hill country, the Negev, and the foothills.
- 9 After that, the men of Judah went down to fight against the Canaanites living in the hill country, the Negev and the western foothills.
- 10 Judah had gone on to the Canaanites who lived in Hebron (Hebron used to be called Kiriath Arba) and brought Sheshai, Ahiman, and Talmi to their knees.
- 10 They advanced against the Canaanites living in Hebron (formerly called Kiriath Arba) and defeated Sheshai, Ahiman and Talmi.
- 11 From there they had marched against the population of Debir (Debir used to be called Kiriath Sepher).
- 11 From there they advanced against the people living in Debir (formerly called Kiriath Sepher).
- 12 Caleb had said, "Whoever attacks Kiriath Sepher and takes it, I'll give my daughter Acsah to him as his wife."
- 12 And Caleb said, "I will give my daughter Acsah in marriage to the man who attacks and captures Kiriath Sepher."
- 13 Othniel son of Kenaz, Caleb's brother, took it, so Caleb gave him his daughter Acsah as his wife.
- 13 Othniel son of Kenaz, Caleb's younger brother, took it; so Caleb gave his daughter Acsah to him in marriage.
- 14 When she arrived she got him to ask for farm land from her father. As she dismounted from her donkey Caleb asked her, "What would you like?"

- 14 One day when she came to Othniel, she urged him to ask her father for a field. When she got off her donkey, Caleb asked her, "What can I do for you?"
- 15 She said, "Give me a marriage gift. You've given me desert land; Now give me pools of water!" And he gave her the upper and the lower pools.
- 15 She replied, "Do me a special favor. Since you have given me land in the Negev, give me also springs of water." Then Caleb gave her the upper and lower springs.
- 16 The people of Hobab the Kenite, Moses' relative, went up with the people of Judah from the City of Palms to the wilderness of Judah at the descent of Arad. They settled down there with the Amalekites.
- 16 The descendants of Moses' father-in-law, the Kenite, went up from the City of Palms with the men of Judah to live among the people of the Desert of Judah in the Negev near Arad.
- 17 The people of Judah went with their kin the Simeonites and struck the Canaanites who lived in Zephath. They carried out the holy curse and named the city Curse-town.
- 17 Then the men of Judah went with the Simeonites their brothers and attacked the Canaanites living in Zephath, and they totally destroyed the city. Therefore it was called Hormah.
- 18 But Judah didn't manage to capture Gaza, Ashkelon, and Ekron with their territories.
- 18 The men of Judah also took Gaza, Ashkelon and Ekron--each city with its territory.
- 19 GOD was certainly with Judah in that they took over the hill country. But they couldn't oust the people on the plain because they had iron chariots.
- 19 The LORD was with the men of Judah. They took possession of the hill country, but they were unable to drive the people from the plains, because they had iron chariots.
- 20 They gave Hebron to Caleb, as Moses had directed. Caleb drove out the three sons of Anak.
- 20 As Moses had promised, Hebron was given to Caleb, who drove from it the three sons of Anak.
- 21 But the people of Benjamin couldn't get rid of the Jebusites living in Jerusalem. Benjaminites and Jebusites live side by side in Jerusalem to

this day.

21 The Benjamites, however, failed to dislodge the Jebusites, who were living in Jerusalem; to this day the Jebusites live there with the Benjamites.

22 The house of Joseph went up to attack Bethel. GOD was with them.

22 Now the house of Joseph attacked Bethel, and the LORD was with them.

23 Joseph sent out spies to look the place over. Bethel used to be known as Luz.

23 When they sent men to spy out Bethel (formerly called Luz),

24 The spies saw a man leaving the city and said to him, "Show us a way into the city and we'll treat you well."

24 the spies saw a man coming out of the city and they said to him, "Show us how to get into the city and we will see that you are treated well."

25 The man showed them a way in. They killed everyone in the city but the man and his family.

25 So he showed them, and they put the city to the sword but spared the man and his whole family.

26 The man went to Hittite country and built a city. He named it Luz; that's its name to this day.

26 He then went to the land of the Hittites, where he built a city and called it Luz, which is its name to this day.

27 But Manasseh never managed to drive out Beth Shan, Taanach, Dor, Ibleam, and Megiddo with their territories. The Canaanites dug in their heels and wouldn't budge.

27 But Manasseh did not drive out the people of Beth Shan or Taanach or Dor or Ibleam or Megiddo and their surrounding settlements, for the Canaanites were determined to live in that land.

28 When Israel became stronger they put the Canaanites to forced labor, but they never got rid of them.

28 When Israel became strong, they pressed the Canaanites into forced labor but never drove them out completely.

29 Neither did Ephraim drive out the Canaanites who lived in Gezer. The Canaanites stuck it out and lived there with them.

29 Nor did Ephraim drive out the Canaanites living in Gezer, but the Canaanites continued to live there among them.

- 30 Nor did Zebulun drive out the Canaanites in Kitron or Nahalol. They kept living there, but they were put to forced labor.
- 30 Neither did Zebulun drive out the Canaanites living in Kitron or Nahalol, who remained among them; but they did subject them to forced labor.
- 31 Nor did Asher drive out the people of Acco, Sidon, Ahlab, Aczib, Helbah, Aphek, and Rehob.
- 31 Nor did Asher drive out those living in Acco or Sidon or Ahlab or Aczib or Helbah or Aphek or Rehob,
- 32 Asher went ahead and settled down with the Canaanites since they could not get rid of them.
- 32 and because of this the people of Asher lived among the Canaanite inhabitants of the land.
- 33 Naphtali fared no better. They couldn't drive out the people of Beth Shemesh or Beth Anath so they just moved in and lived with them. They did, though, put them to forced labor.
- 33 Neither did Naphtali drive out those living in Beth Shemesh or Beth Anath; but the Naphtalites too lived among the Canaanite inhabitants of the land, and those living in Beth Shemesh and Beth Anath became forced laborers for them.
- 34 The Amorites pushed the people of Dan up into the hills and wouldn't let them down on the plains.
- 34 The Amorites confined the Danites to the hill country, not allowing them to come down into the plain.
- 35 The Amorites stubbornly continued to live in Mount Heres, Aijalon, and Shaalbim. But when the house of Joseph got the upper hand, they were put to forced labor.
- 35 And the Amorites were determined also to hold out in Mount Heres, Aijalon and Shaalbim, but when the power of the house of Joseph increased, they too were pressed into forced labor.
- 36 The Amorite border extended from Scorpions' Pass and Sela upward.
- 36 The boundary of the Amorites was from Scorpion Pass to Sela and beyond.

Judges 2

MSG

NIV

- 1 GOD's angel went up from Gilgal to Bokim and said, "I brought you out of Egypt; I led you to the land that I promised to your fathers; and I said, I'll never break my covenant with you--never!
- 1 The angel of the LORD went up from Gilgal to Bokim and said, "I brought you up out of Egypt and led you into the land that I swore to give to your forefathers. I said, 'I will never break my covenant with you,
- 2 And you're never to make a covenant with the people who live in this land. Tear down their altars! But you haven't obeyed me! What's this that you're doing?
- 2 and you shall not make a covenant with the people of this land, but you shall break down their altars.' Yet you have disobeyed me. Why have you done this?
- 3 "So now I'm telling you that I won't drive them out before you. They'll trip you up and their gods will become a trap."
- 3 Now therefore I tell you that I will not drive them out before you; they will be thorns in your sides and their gods will be a snare to you."
- 4 When GOD's angel had spoken these words to all the People of Israel, they cried out--oh! how they wept!
- 4 When the angel of the LORD had spoken these things to all the Israelites, the people wept aloud,
- 5 They named the place Bokim (Weepers). And there they sacrificed to GOD.
- 5 and they called that place Bokim. There they offered sacrifices to the LORD.
- 6 After Joshua had dismissed them, the People of Israel went off to claim their allotted territories and take possession of the land.
- 6 After Joshua had dismissed the Israelites, they went to take possession of the land, each to his own inheritance.
- 7 The people worshiped GOD throughout the lifetime of Joshua and the time of the leaders who survived him, leaders who had been in on all of GOD's great work that he had done for Israel.
- 7 The people served the LORD throughout the lifetime of Joshua and of the elders who outlived him and who had seen all the great things the LORD had done for Israel.

- 8 Then Joshua son of Nun, the servant of GOD, died. He was 110 years old.
- 8 Joshua son of Nun, the servant of the LORD, died at the age of a hundred and ten.
- 9 They buried him in his allotted inheritance at Timnath Heres in the hills of Ephraim north of Mount Gaash.
- 9 And they buried him in the land of his inheritance, at Timnath Heres in the hill country of Ephraim, north of Mount Gaash.
- 10 Eventually that entire generation died and was buried. Then another generation grew up that didn't know anything of GOD or the work he had done for Israel.
- 10 After that whole generation had been gathered to their fathers, another generation grew up, who knew neither the LORD nor what he had done for Israel.
- 11 The People of Israel did evil in GOD's sight:
- 11 Then the Israelites did evil in the eyes of the LORD and served the Baals.
- 12 they served Baal-gods; they deserted GOD, the God of their parents who had led them out of Egypt; they took up with other gods, gods of the peoples around them. They actually worshiped them! And oh, how they angered GOD
- 12 They forsook the LORD, the God of their fathers, who had brought them out of Egypt. They followed and worshiped various gods of the peoples around them. They provoked the LORD to anger
- 13 as they worshiped god Baal and goddess Astarte!
- 13 because they forsook him and served Baal and the Ashtoreths.
- 14 GOD's anger was hot against Israel: He handed them off to plunderers who stripped them; he sold them cheap to enemies on all sides. They were helpless before their enemies.
- 14 In his anger against Israel the LORD handed them over to raiders who plundered them. He sold them to their enemies all around, whom they were no longer able to resist.
- 15 Every time they walked out the door GOD was with them--but for evil, just as GOD had said, just as he had sworn he would do. They were in a bad way.

- 15 Whenever Israel went out to fight, the hand of the LORD was against them to defeat them, just as he had sworn to them. They were in great distress.
- 16 But then GOD raised up judges who saved them from their plunderers.
- 16 Then the LORD raised up judges, who saved them out of the hands of these raiders.
- 17 But they wouldn't listen to their judges; they prostituted themselves to other gods--worshiped them! They lost no time leaving the road walked by their parents, the road of obedience to GOD's commands. They refused to have anything to do with it.
- 17 Yet they would not listen to their judges but prostituted themselves to other gods and worshiped them. Unlike their fathers, they quickly turned from the way in which their fathers had walked, the way of obedience to the LORD's commands.
- 18 When GOD was setting up judges for them, he would be right there with the judge: He would save them from their enemies' oppression as long as the judge was alive, for GOD was moved to compassion when he heard their groaning because of those who afflicted and beat them.
- 18 Whenever the LORD raised up a judge for them, he was with the judge and saved them out of the hands of their enemies as long as the judge lived; for the LORD had compassion on them as they groaned under those who oppressed and afflicted them.
- 19 But when the judge died, the people went right back to their old ways--but even worse than their parents!--running after other gods, serving and worshiping them. Stubborn as mules, they didn't drop a single evil practice.
- 19 But when the judge died, the people returned to ways even more corrupt than those of their fathers, following other gods and serving and worshiping them. They refused to give up their evil practices and stubborn ways.
- 20 And GOD's anger blazed against Israel. He said, "Because these people have thrown out my covenant that I commanded their parents and haven't listened to me,
- 20 Therefore the LORD was very angry with Israel and said, "Because this nation has violated the covenant that I laid down for their forefathers and has not listened to me,

- 21 I'm not driving out one more person from the nations that Joshua left behind when he died.
- 21 I will no longer drive out before them any of the nations Joshua left when he died.
- 22 I'll use them to test Israel and see whether they stay on GOD's road and walk down it as their parents did."
- 22 I will use them to test Israel and see whether they will keep the way of the LORD and walk in it as their forefathers did."
- 23 That's why GOD let those nations remain. He didn't drive them out or let Joshua get rid of them.
- 23 The LORD had allowed those nations to remain; he did not drive them out at once by giving them into the hands of Joshua.

Judges 3

MSG

NIV

- 1 These are the nations that GOD left there, using them to test the Israelites who had no experience in the Canaanite wars.
- 1 These are the nations the LORD left to test all those Israelites who had not experienced any of the wars in Canaan
- 2 He did it to train the descendants of Israel, the ones who had no battle experience, in the art of war.
- 2 (he did this only to teach warfare to the descendants of the Israelites who had not had previous battle experience):
- 3 He left the five Philistine tyrants, all the Canaanites, the Sidonians, and the Hivites living on Mount Lebanon from Mount Baal Hermon to Hamath's Pass.
- 3 the five rulers of the Philistines, all the Canaanites, the Sidonians, and the Hivites living in the Lebanon mountains from Mount Baal Hermon to Lebo Hamath.
- 4 They were there to test Israel and see whether they would obey GOD's commands that were given to their parents through Moses.
- 4 They were left to test the Israelites to see whether they would obey the LORD's commands, which he had given their forefathers through Moses.

- 5 But the People of Israel made themselves at home among the Canaanites, Hittites, Amorites, Perizzites, Hivites, and Jebusites.
- 5 The Israelites lived among the Canaanites, Hittites, Amorites, Perizzites, Hivites and Jebusites.
- 6 They married their daughters and gave their own daughters to their sons in marriage. And they worshiped their gods.
- 6 They took their daughters in marriage and gave their own daughters to their sons, and served their gods.
- 7 The People of Israel did evil in GOD's sight. They forgot their GOD and worshiped the Baal gods and Asherah goddesses.
- 7 The Israelites did evil in the eyes of the LORD; they forgot the LORD their God and served the Baals and the Asherahs.
- 8 GOD's hot anger blazed against Israel. He sold them off to Cushan-Rishathaim king of Aram Naharaim. The People of Israel were in servitude to Cushan-Rishathaim for eight years.
- 8 The anger of the LORD burned against Israel so that he sold them into the hands of Cushan-Rishathaim king of Aram Naharaim, to whom the Israelites were subject for eight years.
- 9 The People of Israel cried out to GOD and GOD raised up a savior who rescued them: Caleb's nephew Othniel, son of his younger brother Kenaz.
- 9 But when they cried out to the LORD, he raised up for them a deliverer, Othniel son of Kenaz, Caleb's younger brother, who saved them.
- 10 The Spirit of GOD came on him and he rallied Israel. He went out to war and GOD gave him Cushan-Rishathaim king of Aram Naharaim. Othniel made short work of him.
- 10 The Spirit of the LORD came upon him, so that he became Israel's judge and went to war. The LORD gave Cushan-Rishathaim king of Aram into the hands of Othniel, who overpowered him.
- 11 The land was quiet for forty years. Then Othniel son of Kenaz died.
- 11 So the land had peace for forty years, until Othniel son of Kenaz died.
- 12 But the People of Israel went back to doing evil in GOD's sight. So GOD made Eglon king of Moab a power against Israel because they did evil in GOD's sight.
- 12 Once again the Israelites did evil in the eyes of the LORD, and because they did this evil the LORD gave Eglon king of Moab power over Israel.

- 13 He recruited the Ammonites and Amalekites and went out and struck Israel. They took the City of Palms.
- 13 Getting the Ammonites and Amalekites to join him, Eglon came and attacked Israel, and they took possession of the City of Palms.
- 14 The People of Israel were in servitude to Eglon fourteen years.
- 14 The Israelites were subject to Eglon king of Moab for eighteen years.
- 15 The People of Israel cried out to GOD and GOD raised up for them a savior, Ehud son of Gera, a Benjaminite. He was left-handed. The People of Israel sent tribute by him to Eglon king of Moab.
- 15 Again the Israelites cried out to the LORD, and he gave them a deliverer--Ehud, a left-handed man, the son of Gera the Benjamite. The Israelites sent him with tribute to Eglon king of Moab.
- 16 Ehud made himself a short two-edged sword and strapped it on his right thigh under his clothes.
- 16 Now Ehud had made a double-edged sword about a foot and a half long, which he strapped to his right thigh under his clothing.
- 17 He presented the tribute to Eglon king of Moab. Eglon was grossly fat.
- 17 He presented the tribute to Eglon king of Moab, who was a very fat man.
- 18 After Ehud finished presenting the tribute, he went a little way with the men who had carried it.
- 18 After Ehud had presented the tribute, he sent on their way the men who had carried it.
- 19 But when he got as far as the stone images near Gilgal, he went back and said, "I have a private message for you, O king." The king told his servants, "Leave." They all left.
- 19 At the idols near Gilgal he himself turned back and said, "I have a secret message for you, O king." The king said, "Quiet!" And all his attendants left him.
- 20 Ehud approached him--the king was now quite alone in his cool rooftop room--and said, "I have a word of God for you." Eglon stood up from his throne.
- 20 Ehud then approached him while he was sitting alone in the upper room of his summer palace and said, "I have a message from God for you." As the king rose from his seat,

- 21 Ehud reached with his left hand and took his sword from his right thigh and plunged it into the king's big belly.
- 21 Ehud reached with his left hand, drew the sword from his right thigh and plunged it into the king's belly.
- 22 Not only the blade but the hilt went in. The fat closed in over it so he couldn't pull it out.
- 22 Even the handle sank in after the blade, which came out his back. Ehud did not pull the sword out, and the fat closed in over it.
- 23 Ehud slipped out by way of the porch and shut and locked the doors of the rooftop room behind him.
- 23 Then Ehud went out to the porch; he shut the doors of the upper room behind him and locked them.
- 24 Then he was gone. When the servants came, they saw with surprise that the doors to the rooftop room were locked. They said, "He's probably relieving himself in the restroom."
- 24 After he had gone, the servants came and found the doors of the upper room locked. They said, "He must be relieving himself in the inner room of the house."
- 25 They waited. And then they worried--no one was coming out of those locked doors. Finally, they got a key and unlocked them. There was their master, fallen on the floor, dead!
- 25 They waited to the point of embarrassment, but when he did not open the doors of the room, they took a key and unlocked them. There they saw their lord fallen to the floor, dead.
- 26 While they were standing around wondering what to do, Ehud was long gone. He got past the stone images and escaped to Seirah.
- 26 While they waited, Ehud got away. He passed by the idols and escaped to Seirah.
- 27 When he got there, he sounded the trumpet on Mount Ephraim. The People of Israel came down from the hills and joined him. He took his place at their head.
- 27 When he arrived there, he blew a trumpet in the hill country of Ephraim, and the Israelites went down with him from the hills, with him leading them.
- 28 He said, "Follow me, for GOD has given your enemies--yes, Moab!--to you." They went down after him and secured the fords of the Jordan

against the Moabites. They let no one cross over.

- 28 Follow me, he ordered, "for the LORD has given Moab, your enemy, into your hands." So they followed him down and, taking possession of the fords of the Jordan that led to Moab, they allowed no one to cross over.
- 29 At that time, they struck down about ten companies of Moabites, all of them well-fed and robust. Not one escaped.
- 29 At that time they struck down about ten thousand Moabites, all vigorous and strong; not a man escaped.
- 30 That day Moab was subdued under the hand of Israel. The land was quiet for eighty years.
- 30 That day Moab was made subject to Israel, and the land had peace for eighty years.
- 31 Shamgar son of Anath came after Ehud. Using a cattle prod, he killed six hundred Philistines single-handed. He too saved Israel.
- 31 After Ehud came Shamgar son of Anath, who struck down six hundred Philistines with an oxgoad. He too saved Israel.

Judges 4

MSG

NIV

- 1 The People of Israel kept right on doing evil in GOD's sight. With Ehud dead,
- 1 After Ehud died, the Israelites once again did evil in the eyes of the LORD.
- 2 GOD sold them off to Jabin king of Canaan who ruled from Hazor. Sisera, who lived in Harosheth Haggoyim, was the commander of his army.
- 2 So the LORD sold them into the hands of Jabin, a king of Canaan, who reigned in Hazor. The commander of his army was Sisera, who lived in Harosheth Haggoyim.
- 3 The People of Israel cried out to GOD because he had cruelly oppressed them with his nine hundred iron chariots for twenty years.
- 3 Because he had nine hundred iron chariots and had cruelly oppressed the Israelites for twenty years, they cried to the LORD for help.

- 4 Deborah was a prophet, the wife of Lappidoth. She was judge over Israel at that time.
- 4 Deborah, a prophetess, the wife of Lappidoth, was leading Israel at that time.
- 5 She held court under Deborah's Palm between Ramah and Bethel in the hills of Ephraim. The People of Israel went to her in matters of justice.
- 5 She held court under the Palm of Deborah between Ramah and Bethel in the hill country of Ephraim, and the Israelites came to her to have their disputes decided.
- 6 She sent for Barak son of Abinoam from Kedesh in Naphtali and said to him, "It has become clear that GOD, the God of Israel, commands you: Go to Mount Tabor and prepare for battle. Take ten companies of soldiers from Naphtali and Zebulun.
- 6 She sent for Barak son of Abinoam from Kedesh in Naphtali and said to him, "The LORD, the God of Israel, commands you: 'Go, take with you ten thousand men of Naphtali and Zebulun and lead the way to Mount Tabor.
- 7 I'll take care of getting Sisera, the leader of Jabin's army, to the Kishon River with all his chariots and troops. And I'll make sure you win the battle."
- 7 I will lure Sisera, the commander of Jabin's army, with his chariots and his troops to the Kishon River and give him into your hands.' "
- 8 Barak said, "If you go with me, I'll go. But if you don't go with me, I won't go."
- 8 Barak said to her, "If you go with me, I will go; but if you don't go with me, I won't go."
- 9 She said, "Of course I'll go with you. But understand that with an attitude like that, there'll be no glory in it for you. GOD will use a woman's hand to take care of Sisera." Deborah got ready and went with Barak to Kedesh.
- 9 Very well, Deborah said, "I will go with you. But because of the way you are going about this, the honor will not be yours, for the LORD will hand Sisera over to a woman." So Deborah went with Barak to Kedesh,
- 10 Barak called Zebulun and Naphtali together at Kedesh. Ten companies of men followed him. And Deborah was with him.

- 10 where he summoned Zebulun and Naphtali. Ten thousand men followed him, and Deborah also went with him.
- 11 It happened that Heber the Kenite had parted company with the other Kenites, the descendants of Hobab, Moses' in-law. He was now living at Zaanannim Oak near Kedesh.
- 11 Now Heber the Kenite had left the other Kenites, the descendants of Hobab, Moses' brother-in-law, and pitched his tent by the great tree in Zaanannim near Kedesh.
- 12 They told Sisera that Barak son of Abinoam had gone up to Mount Tabor.
- 12 When they told Sisera that Barak son of Abinoam had gone up to Mount Tabor,
- 13 Sisera immediately called up all his chariots to the Kishon River--nine hundred iron chariots!--along with all his troops who were with him at Harosheth Haggoyim.
- 13 Sisera gathered together his nine hundred iron chariots and all the men with him, from Harosheth Haggoyim to the Kishon River.
- 14 Deborah said to Barak, "Charge! This very day GOD has given you victory over Sisera. Isn't GOD marching before you?" Barak charged down the slopes of Mount Tabor, his ten companies following him.
- 14 Then Deborah said to Barak, "Go! This is the day the LORD has given Sisera into your hands. Has not the LORD gone ahead of you?" So Barak went down Mount Tabor, followed by ten thousand men.
- 15 GOD routed Sisera--all those chariots, all those troops!--before Barak. Sisera jumped out of his chariot and ran.
- 15 At Barak's advance, the LORD routed Sisera and all his chariots and army by the sword, and Sisera abandoned his chariot and fled on foot.
- 16 Barak chased the chariots and troops all the way to Harosheth Haggoyim. Sisera's entire fighting force was killed--not one man left.
- 16 But Barak pursued the chariots and army as far as Harosheth Haggoyim. All the troops of Sisera fell by the sword; not a man was left.
- 17 Meanwhile Sisera, running for his life, headed for the tent of Jael, wife of Heber the Kenite. Jabin king of Hazor and Heber the Kenite were on good terms with one another.
- 17 Sisera, however, fled on foot to the tent of Jael, the wife of Heber the Kenite, because there were friendly relations between Jabin king of

Hazor and the clan of Heber the Kenite.

- 18 Jael stepped out to meet Sisera and said, "Come in, sir. Stay here with me. Don't be afraid." So he went with her into her tent. She covered him with a blanket.
- 18 Jael went out to meet Sisera and said to him, "Come, my lord, come right in. Don't be afraid." So he entered her tent, and she put a covering over him.
- 19 He said to her, "Please, a little water. I'm thirsty." She opened a bottle of milk, gave him a drink, and then covered him up again.
- 19 I'm thirsty, he said. "Please give me some water." She opened a skin of milk, gave him a drink, and covered him up.
- 20 He then said, "Stand at the tent flap. If anyone comes by and asks you, 'Is there anyone here?' tell him, 'No, not a soul.'"
- 20 Stand in the doorway of the tent, he told her. "If someone comes by and asks you, 'Is anyone here?' say 'No.' "
- 21 Then while he was fast asleep from exhaustion, Jael wife of Heber took a tent peg and hammer, tiptoed toward him, and drove the tent peg through his temple and all the way into the ground. He convulsed and died.
- 21 But Jael, Heber's wife, picked up a tent peg and a hammer and went quietly to him while he lay fast asleep, exhausted. She drove the peg through his temple into the ground, and he died.
- 22 Barak arrived in pursuit of Sisera. Jael went out to greet him. She said, "Come, I'll show you the man you're looking for." He went with her and there he was--Sisera, stretched out, dead, with a tent peg through his neck.
- 22 Barak came by in pursuit of Sisera, and Jael went out to meet him. "Come," she said, "I will show you the man you're looking for." So he went in with her, and there lay Sisera with the tent peg through his temple--dead.
- 23 On that day God subdued Jabin king of Canaan before the People of Israel.
- 23 On that day God subdued Jabin, the Canaanite king, before the Israelites.
- 24 The People of Israel pressed harder and harder on Jabin king of Canaan until there was nothing left of him.

24 And the hand of the Israelites grew stronger and stronger against Jabin, the Canaanite king, until they destroyed him.

Judges 5

MSG

NIV

- 1 That day Deborah and Barak son of Abinoam sang this song:
- 1 On that day Deborah and Barak son of Abinoam sang this song:
- 2 When they let down their hair in Israel, they let it blow wild in the wind. The people volunteered with abandon, bless GOD!
- 2 When the princes in Israel take the lead, when the people willingly offer themselves-- praise the LORD!
- 3 Hear O kings! Listen O princes! To GOD, yes to GOD, I'll sing, Make music to GOD, to the God of Israel.
- 3 Hear this, you kings! Listen, you rulers! I will sing to the LORD, I will sing; I will make music to the LORD, the God of Israel.
- 4 GOD, when you left Seir, marched across the fields of Edom, Earth quaked, yes, the skies poured rain, oh, the clouds made rivers.
- 4 O LORD, when you went out from Seir, when you marched from the land of Edom, the earth shook, the heavens poured, the clouds poured down water.
- 5 Mountains leapt before GOD, the Sinai God, before GOD, the God of Israel.
- 5 The mountains quaked before the LORD, the One of Sinai, before the LORD, the God of Israel.
- 6 In the time of Shamgar son of Anath, and in the time of Jael, Public roads were abandoned, travelers went by backroads.
- 6 In the days of Shamgar son of Anath, in the days of Jael, the roads were abandoned; travelers took to winding paths.
- 7 Warriors became fat and sloppy, no fight left in them. Then you, Deborah, rose up; you got up, a mother in Israel.
- 7 Village life in Israel ceased, ceased until I, Deborah, arose, arose a mother in Israel.
- 8 God chose new leaders, who then fought at the gates. And not a shield or spear to be seen among the forty companies of Israel.

- 8 When they chose new gods, war came to the city gates, and not a shield or spear was seen among forty thousand in Israel.
- 9 Lift your hearts high, O Israel, with abandon, volunteering yourselves with the people--bless GOD!
- 9 My heart is with Israel's princes, with the willing volunteers among the people. Praise the LORD!
- 10 You who ride on prize donkeys comfortably mounted on blankets And you who walk down the roads, ponder, attend!
- 10 You who ride on white donkeys, sitting on your saddle blankets, and you who walk along the road, consider
- 11 Gather at the town well and listen to them sing, Chanting the tale of GOD's victories, his victories accomplished in Israel. Then the people of GOD went down to the city gates.
- 11 the voice of the singers at the watering places. They recite the righteous acts of the LORD, the righteous acts of his warriors in Israel. "Then the people of the LORD went down to the city gates.
- 12 Wake up, wake up, Deborah! Wake up, wake up, sing a song! On your feet, Barak! Take your prisoners, son of Abinoam!
- 12 'Wake up, wake up, Deborah! Wake up, wake up, break out in song! Arise, O Barak! Take captive your captives, O son of Abinoam.'
- 13 Then the remnant went down to greet the brave ones. The people of GOD joined the mighty ones.
- 13 Then the men who were left came down to the nobles; the people of the LORD came to me with the mighty.
- 14 The captains from Ephraim came to the valley, behind you, Benjamin, with your troops. Captains marched down from Makir, from Zebulun high-ranking leaders came down.
- 14 Some came from Ephraim, whose roots were in Amalek; Benjamin was with the people who followed you. From Makir captains came down, from Zebulun those who bear a commander's staff.
- 15 Issachar's princes rallied to Deborah, Issachar stood fast with Barak, backing him up on the field of battle. But in Reuben's divisions there was much second-guessing.
- 15 The princes of Issachar were with Deborah; yes, Issachar was with Barak, rushing after him into the valley. In the districts of Reuben there was much searching of heart.

- 16 Why all those campfire discussions? Diverted and distracted, Reuben's divisions couldn't make up their minds.
- 16 Why did you stay among the campfires to hear the whistling for the flocks? In the districts of Reuben there was much searching of heart.
- 17 Gilead played it safe across the Jordan, and Dan, why did he go off sailing? Asher kept his distance on the seacoast, safe and secure in his harbors.
- 17 Gilead stayed beyond the Jordan. And Dan, why did he linger by the ships? Asher remained on the coast and stayed in his coves.
- 18 But Zebulun risked life and limb, defied death, as did Naphtali on the battle heights.
- 18 The people of Zebulun risked their very lives; so did Naphtali on the heights of the field.
- 19 The kings came, they fought, the kings of Canaan fought. At Taanach they fought, at Megiddo's brook, but they took no silver, no plunder.
- 19 Kings came, they fought; the kings of Canaan fought at Taanach by the waters of Megiddo, but they carried off no silver, no plunder.
- 20 The stars in the sky joined the fight, from their courses they fought against Sisera.
- 20 From the heavens the stars fought, from their courses they fought against Sisera.
- 21 The torrent Kishon swept them away, the torrent attacked them, the torrent Kishon. Oh, you'll stomp on the necks of the strong!
- 21 The river Kishon swept them away, the age-old river, the river Kishon. March on, my soul; be strong!
- 22 Then the hoofs of the horses pounded, charging, stampeding stallions.
- 22 Then thundered the horses' hoofs-- galloping, galloping go his mighty steeds.
- 23 "Curse Meroz," says GOD's angel. "Curse, double curse, its people, Because they didn't come when GOD needed them, didn't rally to GOD's side with valiant fighters."
- 23 'Curse Meroz,' said the angel of the LORD. 'Curse its people bitterly, because they did not come to help the LORD, to help the LORD against the mighty.'
- 24 Most blessed of all women is Jael, wife of Heber the Kenite, most blessed of homemaking women.

- 24 Most blessed of women be Jael, the wife of Heber the Kenite, most blessed of tent-dwelling women.
- 25 He asked for water, she brought milk; In a handsome bowl, she offered cream.
- 25 He asked for water, and she gave him milk; in a bowl fit for nobles she brought him curdled milk.
- 26 She grabbed a tent peg in her left hand, with her right hand she seized a hammer. She hammered Sisera, she smashed his head, she drove a hole through his head.
- 26 Her hand reached for the tent peg, her right hand for the workman's hammer. She struck Sisera, she crushed his head, she shattered and pierced his temple.
- 27 He slumped at her feet. He fell. He sprawled. He slumped at her feet. He fell. Slumped. Fallen. Dead.
- 27 At her feet he sank, he fell; there he lay. At her feet he sank, he fell; where he sank, there he fell--dead.
- 28 Sisera's mother waited at the window, a weary, anxious watch. "What's keeping his chariot? What delays his chariot's rumble?"
- 28 Through the window peered Sisera's mother; behind the lattice she cried out, 'Why is his chariot so long in coming? Why is the clatter of his chariots delayed?'
- 29 The wisest of her ladies-in-waiting answers with calm, reassuring words,
- 29 The wisest of her ladies answer her; indeed, she keeps saying to herself,
- 30 "Don't you think they're busy at plunder, dividing up the loot? A girl, maybe two girls, for each man, And for Sisera a bright silk shirt, a prize, fancy silk shirt! And a colorful scarf--make it two scarves-- to grace the neck of the plunderer."
- 30 'Are they not finding and dividing the spoils: a girl or two for each man, colorful garments as plunder for Sisera, colorful garments embroidered, highly embroidered garments for my neck-- all this as plunder?'
- 31 Thus may all GOD's enemies perish, while his lovers be like the unclouded sun. The land was quiet for forty years.
- 31 So may all your enemies perish, O LORD! But may they who love you be like the sun when it rises in its strength. Then the land had peace forty years.

Judges 6

MSG

NIV

- 1 Yet again the People of Israel went back to doing evil in GOD's sight. GOD put them under the domination of Midian for seven years.
- 1 Again the Israelites did evil in the eyes of the LORD, and for seven years he gave them into the hands of the Midianites.
- 2 Midian overpowered Israel. Because of Midian, the People of Israel made for themselves hideouts in the mountains--caves and forts.
- 2 Because the power of Midian was so oppressive, the Israelites prepared shelters for themselves in mountain clefts, caves and strongholds.
- 3 When Israel planted its crops, Midian and Amalek, the easterners, would invade them,
- 3 Whenever the Israelites planted their crops, the Midianites, Amalekites and other eastern peoples invaded the country.
- 4 camp in their fields, and destroy their crops all the way down to Gaza. They left nothing for them to live on, neither sheep nor ox nor donkey.
- 4 They camped on the land and ruined the crops all the way to Gaza and did not spare a living thing for Israel, neither sheep nor cattle nor donkeys.
- 5 Bringing their cattle and tents, they came in and took over, like an invasion of locusts. And their camels--past counting! They marched in and devastated the country.
- 5 They came up with their livestock and their tents like swarms of locusts. It was impossible to count the men and their camels; they invaded the land to ravage it.
- 6 The People of Israel, reduced to grinding poverty by Midian, cried out to GOD for help.
- 6 Midian so impoverished the Israelites that they cried out to the LORD for help.
- 7 One time when the People of Israel had cried out to GOD because of Midian,
- 7 When the Israelites cried to the LORD because of Midian,
- 8 GOD sent them a prophet with this message: "GOD, the God of Israel, says, I delivered you from Egypt, I freed you from a life of slavery;

- 8 he sent them a prophet, who said, "This is what the LORD, the God of Israel, says: I brought you up out of Egypt, out of the land of slavery.
- 9 I rescued you from Egypt's brutality and then from every oppressor; I pushed them out of your way and gave you their land.
- 9 I snatched you from the power of Egypt and from the hand of all your oppressors. I drove them from before you and gave you their land.
- 10 "And I said to you, 'I am GOD, your God. Don't for a minute be afraid of the gods of the Amorites in whose land you are living.' But you didn't listen to me."
- 10 I said to you, 'I am the LORD your God; do not worship the gods of the Amorites, in whose land you live.' But you have not listened to me."
- 11 One day the angel of GOD came and sat down under the oak in Ophrah that belonged to Joash the Abiezrite, whose son Gideon was threshing wheat in the winepress, out of sight of the Midianites.
- 11 The angel of the LORD came and sat down under the oak in Ophrah that belonged to Joash the Abiezrite, where his son Gideon was threshing wheat in a winepress to keep it from the Midianites.
- 12 The angel of GOD appeared to him and said, "GOD is with you, O mighty warrior!"
- 12 When the angel of the LORD appeared to Gideon, he said, "The LORD is with you, mighty warrior."
- 13 Gideon replied, "With me, my master? If GOD is with us, why has all this happened to us? Where are all the miracle-wonders our parents and grandparents told us about, telling us, 'Didn't GOD deliver us from Egypt?' The fact is, GOD has nothing to do with us--he has turned us over to Midian."
- 13 But sir, Gideon replied, "if the LORD is with us, why has all this happened to us? Where are all his wonders that our fathers told us about when they said, 'Did not the LORD bring us up out of Egypt?' But now the LORD has abandoned us and put us into the hand of Midian."
- 14 But GOD faced him directly: "Go in this strength that is yours. Save Israel from Midian. Haven't I just sent you?"
- 14 The LORD turned to him and said, "Go in the strength you have and save Israel out of Midian's hand. Am I not sending you?"
- 15 Gideon said to him, "Me, my master? How and with what could I ever save Israel? Look at me. My clan's the weakest in Manasseh and I'm the

runt of the litter."

15 But Lord, Gideon asked, "how can I save Israel? My clan is the weakest in Manasseh, and I am the least in my family."

16 GOD said to him, "I'll be with you. Believe me, you'll defeat Midian as one man."

16 The LORD answered, "I will be with you, and you will strike down all the Midianites together."

17 Gideon said, "If you're serious about this, do me a favor: Give me a sign to back up what you're telling me."

17 Gideon replied, "If now I have found favor in your eyes, give me a sign that it is really you talking to me."

18 Don't leave until I come back and bring you my gift." He said, "I'll wait till you get back."

18 Please do not go away until I come back and bring my offering and set it before you." And the LORD said, "I will wait until you return."

19 Gideon went and prepared a young goat and a huge amount of unraised bread (he used over half a bushel of flour!). He put the meat in a basket and the broth in a pot and took them back under the shade of the oak tree for a sacred meal.

19 Gideon went in, prepared a young goat, and from an ephah of flour he made bread without yeast. Putting the meat in a basket and its broth in a pot, he brought them out and offered them to him under the oak.

20 The angel of God said to him, "Take the meat and unraised bread, place them on that rock, and pour the broth on them." Gideon did it.

20 The angel of God said to him, "Take the meat and the unleavened bread, place them on this rock, and pour out the broth." And Gideon did so.

21 The angel of GOD stretched out the tip of the stick he was holding and touched the meat and the bread. Fire broke out of the rock and burned up the meat and bread while the angel of God slipped away out of sight.

21 With the tip of the staff that was in his hand, the angel of the LORD touched the meat and the unleavened bread. Fire flared from the rock, consuming the meat and the bread. And the angel of the LORD disappeared.

22 And Gideon knew it was the angel of God! Gideon said, "Oh no! Master, GOD! I have seen the angel of God face to face!"

22 When Gideon realized that it was the angel of the LORD, he exclaimed, "Ah, Sovereign LORD! I have seen the angel of the LORD face to face!"

23 But GOD reassured him, "Easy now. Don't panic. You won't die."

23 But the LORD said to him, "Peace! Do not be afraid. You are not going to die."

24 Then Gideon built an altar there to GOD and named it "GOD's Peace." It's still called that at Ophrah of Abiezer.

24 So Gideon built an altar to the LORD there and called it The LORD is Peace. To this day it stands in Ophrah of the Abiezrites.

25 That night this happened. GOD said to him, "Take your father's best seven-year-old bull, the prime one. Tear down your father's Baal altar and chop down the Asherah fertility pole beside it.

25 That same night the LORD said to him, "Take the second bull from your father's herd, the one seven years old. Tear down your father's altar to Baal and cut down the Asherah pole beside it.

26 Then build an altar to GOD, your God, on the top of this hill. Take the prime bull and present it as a Whole-Burnt-Offering, using firewood from the Asherah pole that you cut down."

26 Then build a proper kind of altar to the LORD your God on the top of this height. Using the wood of the Asherah pole that you cut down, offer the second bull as a burnt offering."

27 Gideon selected ten men from his servants and did exactly what GOD had told him. But because of his family and the people in the neighborhood, he was afraid to do it openly, so he did it that night.

27 So Gideon took ten of his servants and did as the LORD told him. But because he was afraid of his family and the men of the town, he did it at night rather than in the daytime.

28 Early in the morning, the people in town were shocked to find Baal's altar torn down, the Asherah pole beside it chopped down, and the prime bull burning away on the altar that had been built.

28 In the morning when the men of the town got up, there was Baal's altar, demolished, with the Asherah pole beside it cut down and the second bull sacrificed on the newly built altar!

29 They kept asking, "Who did this?" Questions and more questions, and then the answer: "Gideon son of Joash did it."

- 29 They asked each other, "Who did this?" When they carefully investigated, they were told, "Gideon son of Joash did it."
- 30 The men of the town demanded of Joash: "Bring out your son! He must die! Why, he tore down the Baal altar and chopped down the Asherah tree!"
- 30 The men of the town demanded of Joash, "Bring out your son. He must die, because he has broken down Baal's altar and cut down the Asherah pole beside it."
- 31 But Joash stood up to the crowd pressing in on him, "Are you going to fight Baal's battles for him? Are you going to save him? Anyone who takes Baal's side will be dead by morning. If Baal is a god in fact, let him fight his own battles and defend his own altar."
- 31 But Joash replied to the hostile crowd around him, "Are you going to plead Baal's cause? Are you trying to save him? Whoever fights for him shall be put to death by morning! If Baal really is a god, he can defend himself when someone breaks down his altar."
- 32 They nicknamed Gideon that day Jerub-Baal because after he had torn down the Baal altar, he had said, "Let Baal fight his own battles."
- 32 So that day they called Gideon "Jerub-Baal, " saying, "Let Baal contend with him," because he broke down Baal's altar.
- 33 All the Midianites and Amalekites (the easterners) got together, crossed the river, and made camp in the Valley of Jezreel.
- 33 Now all the Midianites, Amalekites and other eastern peoples joined forces and crossed over the Jordan and camped in the Valley of Jezreel.
- 34 GOD's Spirit came over Gideon. He blew his ram's horn trumpet and the Abiezrites came out, ready to follow him.
- 34 Then the Spirit of the LORD came upon Gideon, and he blew a trumpet, summoning the Abiezrites to follow him.
- 35 He dispatched messengers all through Manasseh, calling them to the battle; also to Asher, Zebulun, and Naphtali. They all came.
- 35 He sent messengers throughout Manasseh, calling them to arms, and also into Asher, Zebulun and Naphtali, so that they too went up to meet them.
- 36 Gideon said to God, "If this is right, if you are using me to save Israel as you've said,

- 36 Gideon said to God, "If you will save Israel by my hand as you have promised--
- 37 then look: I'm placing a fleece of wool on the threshing floor. If dew is on the fleece only, but the floor is dry, then I know that you will use me to save Israel, as you said."
- 37 look, I will place a wool fleece on the threshing floor. If there is dew only on the fleece and all the ground is dry, then I will know that you will save Israel by my hand, as you said."
- 38 That's what happened. When he got up early the next morning, he wrung out the fleece--enough dew to fill a bowl with water!
- 38 And that is what happened. Gideon rose early the next day; he squeezed the fleece and wrung out the dew--a bowlful of water.
- 39 Then Gideon said to God, "Don't be impatient with me, but let me say one more thing. I want to try another time with the fleece. But this time let the fleece stay dry, while the dew drenches the ground."
- 39 Then Gideon said to God, "Do not be angry with me. Let me make just one more request. Allow me one more test with the fleece. This time make the fleece dry and the ground covered with dew."
- 40 God made it happen that very night. Only the fleece was dry while the ground was wet with dew.
- 40 That night God did so. Only the fleece was dry; all the ground was covered with dew.

Judges 7

MSG

NIV

- 1 Jerub-Baal (Gideon) got up early the next morning, all his troops right there with him. They set up camp at Harod's Spring. The camp of Midian was in the plain, north of them near the Hill of Moreh.
- 1 Early in the morning, Jerub-Baal (that is, Gideon) and all his men camped at the spring of Harod. The camp of Midian was north of them in the valley near the hill of Moreh.
- 2 GOD said to Gideon, "You have too large an army with you. I can't turn Midian over to them like this--they'll take all the credit, saying, 'I did it all myself,' and forget about me.

- 2 The LORD said to Gideon, "You have too many men for me to deliver Midian into their hands. In order that Israel may not boast against me that her own strength has saved her,
- 3 Make a public announcement: 'Anyone afraid, anyone who has any qualms at all, may leave Mount Gilead now and go home.'" Twenty-two companies headed for home. Ten companies were left.
- 3 announce now to the people, 'Anyone who trembles with fear may turn back and leave Mount Gilead.' " So twenty-two thousand men left, while ten thousand remained.
- 4 GOD said to Gideon: "There are still too many. Take them down to the stream and I'll make a final cut. When I say, 'This one goes with you,' he'll go. When I say, 'This one doesn't go,' he won't go."
- 4 But the LORD said to Gideon, "There are still too many men. Take them down to the water, and I will sift them for you there. If I say, 'This one shall go with you,' he shall go; but if I say, 'This one shall not go with you,' he shall not go."
- 5 So Gideon took the troops down to the stream. GOD said to Gideon: "Everyone who laps with his tongue, the way a dog laps, set on one side. And everyone who kneels to drink, drinking with his face to the water, set to the other side."
- 5 So Gideon took the men down to the water. There the LORD told him, "Separate those who lap the water with their tongues like a dog from those who kneel down to drink."
- 6 Three hundred lapped with their tongues from their cupped hands. All the rest knelt to drink.
- 6 Three hundred men lapped with their hands to their mouths. All the rest got down on their knees to drink.
- 7 GOD said to Gideon: "I'll use the three hundred men who lapped at the stream to save you and give Midian into your hands. All the rest may go home."
- 7 The LORD said to Gideon, "With the three hundred men that lapped I will save you and give the Midianites into your hands. Let all the other men go, each to his own place."
- 8 After Gideon took all their provisions and trumpets, he sent all the Israelites home. He took up his position with the three hundred. The camp of Midian stretched out below him in the valley.

- 8 So Gideon sent the rest of the Israelites to their tents but kept the three hundred, who took over the provisions and trumpets of the others. Now the camp of Midian lay below him in the valley.
- 9 That night, GOD told Gideon: "Get up and go down to the camp. I've given it to you.
- 9 During that night the LORD said to Gideon, "Get up, go down against the camp, because I am going to give it into your hands.
- 10 If you have any doubts about going down, go down with Purah your armor bearer;
- 10 If you are afraid to attack, go down to the camp with your servant Purah
- 11 when you hear what they're saying, you'll be bold and confident." He and his armor bearer Purah went down near the place where sentries were posted.
- 11 and listen to what they are saying. Afterward, you will be encouraged to attack the camp." So he and Purah his servant went down to the outposts of the camp.
- 12 Midian and Amalek, all the easterners, were spread out on the plain like a swarm of locusts. And their camels! Past counting, like grains of sand on the seashore!
- 12 The Midianites, the Amalekites and all the other eastern peoples had settled in the valley, thick as locusts. Their camels could no more be counted than the sand on the seashore.
- 13 Gideon arrived just in time to hear a man tell his friend a dream. He said, "I had this dream: A loaf of barley bread tumbled into the Midianite camp. It came to the tent and hit it so hard it collapsed. The tent fell!"
- 13 Gideon arrived just as a man was telling a friend his dream. "I had a dream," he was saying. "A round loaf of barley bread came tumbling into the Midianite camp. It struck the tent with such force that the tent overturned and collapsed."
- 14 His friend said, "This has to be the sword of Gideon son of Joash, the Israelite! God has turned Midian--the whole camp!--over to him."
- 14 His friend responded, "This can be nothing other than the sword of Gideon son of Joash, the Israelite. God has given the Midianites and the whole camp into his hands."
- 15 When Gideon heard the telling of the dream and its interpretation, he went to his knees before God in prayer. Then he went back to the

- Israelite camp and said, "Get up and get going! GOD has just given us the Midianite army!"
- 15 When Gideon heard the dream and its interpretation, he worshiped God. He returned to the camp of Israel and called out, "Get up! The LORD has given the Midianite camp into your hands."
- 16 He divided the three hundred men into three companies. He gave each man a trumpet and an empty jar, with a torch in the jar.
- 16 Dividing the three hundred men into three companies, he placed trumpets and empty jars in the hands of all of them, with torches inside.
- 17 He said, "Watch me and do what I do. When I get to the edge of the camp, do exactly what I do.
- 17 Watch me, he told them. "Follow my lead. When I get to the edge of the camp, do exactly as I do.
- 18 When I and those with me blow the trumpets, you also, all around the camp, blow your trumpets and shout, 'For GOD and for Gideon!'"
- 18 When I and all who are with me blow our trumpets, then from all around the camp blow yours and shout, 'For the LORD and for Gideon.'
- "
- 19 Gideon and his hundred men got to the edge of the camp at the beginning of the middle watch, just after the sentries had been posted. They blew the trumpets, at the same time smashing the jars they carried.
- 19 Gideon and the hundred men with him reached the edge of the camp at the beginning of the middle watch, just after they had changed the guard. They blew their trumpets and broke the jars that were in their hands.
- 20 All three companies blew the trumpets and broke the jars. They held the torches in their left hands and the trumpets in their right hands, ready to blow, and shouted, "A sword for GOD and for Gideon!"
- 20 The three companies blew the trumpets and smashed the jars. Grasping the torches in their left hands and holding in their right hands the trumpets they were to blow, they shouted, "A sword for the LORD and for Gideon!"
- 21 They were stationed all around the camp, each man at his post. The whole Midianite camp jumped to its feet. They yelled and fled.
- 21 While each man held his position around the camp, all the Midianites ran, crying out as they fled.

- 22 When the three hundred blew the trumpets, GOD aimed each Midianite's sword against his companion, all over the camp. They ran for their lives--to Beth Shittah, toward Zererah, to the border of Abel Meholah near Tabbath.
- 22 When the three hundred trumpets sounded, the LORD caused the men throughout the camp to turn on each other with their swords. The army fled to Beth Shittah toward Zererah as far as the border of Abel Meholah near Tabbath.
- 23 Israelites rallied from Naphtali, from Asher, and from all over Manasseh. They had Midian on the run.
- 23 Israelites from Naphtali, Asher and all Manasseh were called out, and they pursued the Midianites.
- 24 Gideon then sent messengers through all the hill country of Ephraim, urging them, "Come down against Midian! Capture the fords of the Jordan at Beth Barah."
- 24 Gideon sent messengers throughout the hill country of Ephraim, saying, "Come down against the Midianites and seize the waters of the Jordan ahead of them as far as Beth Barah." So all the men of Ephraim were called out and they took the waters of the Jordan as far as Beth Barah.
- 25 So all the men of Ephraim rallied and captured the fords of the Jordan at Beth Barah. They also captured the two Midianite commanders Oreb (Raven) and Zeeb (Wolf). They killed Oreb at Raven Rock; Zeeb they killed at Wolf Winepress. And they pressed the pursuit of Midian. They brought the heads of Oreb and Zeeb to Gideon across the Jordan.
- 25 They also captured two of the Midianite leaders, Oreb and Zeeb. They killed Oreb at the rock of Oreb, and Zeeb at the winepress of Zeeb. They pursued the Midianites and brought the heads of Oreb and Zeeb to Gideon, who was by the Jordan.

Judges 8

MSG

NIV

- 1 Then the Ephraimites said to Gideon, "Why did you leave us out of this, not calling us when you went to fight Midian?" They were indignant and let him know it.

- 1 Now the Ephraimites asked Gideon, "Why have you treated us like this? Why didn't you call us when you went to fight Midian?" And they criticized him sharply.
- 2 But Gideon replied, "What have I done compared to you? Why, even the gleanings of Ephraim are superior to the vintage of Abiezer.
- 2 But he answered them, "What have I accomplished compared to you? Aren't the gleanings of Ephraim's grapes better than the full grape harvest of Abiezer?
- 3 God gave you Midian's commanders, Oreb and Zeeb. What have I done compared with you?" When they heard this, they calmed down and cooled off.
- 3 God gave Oreb and Zeeb, the Midianite leaders, into your hands. What was I able to do compared to you?" At this, their resentment against him subsided.
- 4 Gideon and his three hundred arrived at the Jordan and crossed over. They were bone-tired but still pressing the pursuit.
- 4 Gideon and his three hundred men, exhausted yet keeping up the pursuit, came to the Jordan and crossed it.
- 5 He asked the men of Succoth, "Please, give me some loaves of bread for my troops I have with me. They're worn out, and I'm hot on the trail of Zebah and Zalmunna, the Midianite kings."
- 5 He said to the men of Succoth, "Give my troops some bread; they are worn out, and I am still pursuing Zebah and Zalmunna, the kings of Midian."
- 6 But the leaders in Succoth said, "You're on a wild goose chase; why should we help you on a fool's errand?"
- 6 But the officials of Succoth said, "Do you already have the hands of Zebah and Zalmunna in your possession? Why should we give bread to your troops?"
- 7 Gideon said, "If you say so. But when GOD gives me Zebah and Zalmunna, I'll give you a thrashing, whip your bare flesh with desert thorns and thistles!"
- 7 Then Gideon replied, "Just for that, when the LORD has given Zebah and Zalmunna into my hand, I will tear your flesh with desert thorns and briers."

- 8 He went from there to Peniel and made the same request. The men of Peniel, like the men of Succoth, also refused.
- 8 From there he went up to Peniel and made the same request of them, but they answered as the men of Succoth had.
- 9 Gideon told them, "When I return safe and sound, I'll demolish this tower."
- 9 So he said to the men of Peniel, "When I return in triumph, I will tear down this tower."
- 10 Zebah and Zalmunna were in Karkor with an army of about fifteen companies, all that was left of the fighting force of the easterners--they had lost 120 companies of soldiers.
- 10 Now Zebah and Zalmunna were in Karkor with a force of about fifteen thousand men, all that were left of the armies of the eastern peoples; a hundred and twenty thousand swordsmen had fallen.
- 11 Gideon went up the caravan trail east of Nobah and Jogbehah, found and attacked the undefended camp.
- 11 Gideon went up by the route of the nomads east of Nobah and Jogbehah and fell upon the unsuspecting army.
- 12 Zebah and Zalmunna fled, but he chased and captured the two kings of Midian. The whole camp had panicked.
- 12 Zebah and Zalmunna, the two kings of Midian, fled, but he pursued them and captured them, routing their entire army.
- 13 Gideon son of Joash returned from the battle by way of the Heres Pass.
- 13 Gideon son of Joash then returned from the battle by the Pass of Heres.
- 14 He captured a young man from Succoth and asked some questions. The young man wrote down the names of the officials and leaders of Succoth, seventy-seven men.
- 14 He caught a young man of Succoth and questioned him, and the young man wrote down for him the names of the seventy-seven officials of Succoth, the elders of the town.
- 15 Then Gideon went to the men of Succoth and said, "Here are the wild geese, Zebah and Zalmunna, you said I'd never catch. You wouldn't give so much as a scrap of bread to my worn-out men; you taunted us, saying that we were on a fool's errand."
- 15 Then Gideon came and said to the men of Succoth, "Here are Zebah and Zalmunna, about whom you taunted me by saying, 'Do you already have

- the hands of Zebah and Zalmunna in your possession? Why should we give bread to your exhausted men?" "
- 16 Then he took the seventy-seven leaders of Succoth and thrashed them with desert thorns and thistles.
- 16 He took the elders of the town and taught the men of Succoth a lesson by punishing them with desert thorns and briers.
- 17 And he demolished the tower of Peniel and killed the men of the city.
- 17 He also pulled down the tower of Peniel and killed the men of the town.
- 18 He then addressed Zebah and Zalmunna: "Tell me about the men you killed at Tabor." "They were men much like you," they said, "each one like a king's son."
- 18 Then he asked Zebah and Zalmunna, "What kind of men did you kill at Tabor?" "Men like you," they answered, "each one with the bearing of a prince."
- 19 Gideon said, "They were my brothers, my mother's sons. As GOD lives, if you had let them live, I would let you live."
- 19 Gideon replied, "Those were my brothers, the sons of my own mother. As surely as the LORD lives, if you had spared their lives, I would not kill you."
- 20 Then he spoke to Jether, his firstborn: "Get up and kill them." But he couldn't do it, couldn't draw his sword. He was afraid--he was still just a boy.
- 20 Turning to Jether, his oldest son, he said, "Kill them!" But Jether did not draw his sword, because he was only a boy and was afraid.
- 21 Zebah and Zalmunna said, "Do it yourself--if you're man enough!" And Gideon did it. He stepped up and killed Zebah and Zalmunna. Then he took the crescents that hung on the necks of their camels.
- 21 Zebah and Zalmunna said, "Come, do it yourself. 'As is the man, so is his strength.' " So Gideon stepped forward and killed them, and took the ornaments off their camels' necks.
- 22 The Israelites said, "Rule over us, you and your son and your grandson. You have saved us from Midian's tyranny."
- 22 The Israelites said to Gideon, "Rule over us--you, your son and your grandson--because you have saved us out of the hand of Midian."
- 23 Gideon said, "I most certainly will not rule over you, nor will my son. GOD will reign over you."

- 23 But Gideon told them, "I will not rule over you, nor will my son rule over you. The LORD will rule over you."
- 24 Then Gideon said, "But I do have one request. Give me, each of you, an earring that you took as plunder." Ishmaelites wore gold earrings, and the men all had their pockets full of them.
- 24 And he said, "I do have one request, that each of you give me an earring from your share of the plunder." (It was the custom of the Ishmaelites to wear gold earrings.)
- 25 They said, "Of course. They're yours!" They spread out a blanket and each man threw his plundered earrings on it.
- 25 They answered, "We'll be glad to give them." So they spread out a garment, and each man threw a ring from his plunder onto it.
- 26 The gold earrings that Gideon had asked for weighed about forty-three pounds--and that didn't include the crescents and pendants, the purple robes worn by the Midianite kings, and the ornaments hung around the necks of their camels.
- 26 The weight of the gold rings he asked for came to seventeen hundred shekels, not counting the ornaments, the pendants and the purple garments worn by the kings of Midian or the chains that were on their camels' necks.
- 27 Gideon made the gold into a sacred ephod and put it on display in his hometown, Ophrah. All Israel prostituted itself there. Gideon and his family, too, were seduced by it.
- 27 Gideon made the gold into an ephod, which he placed in Ophrah, his town. All Israel prostituted themselves by worshiping it there, and it became a snare to Gideon and his family.
- 28 Midian's tyranny was broken by the Israelites; nothing more was heard from them. The land was quiet for forty years in Gideon's time.
- 28 Thus Midian was subdued before the Israelites and did not raise its head again. During Gideon's lifetime, the land enjoyed peace forty years.
- 29 Jerub-Baal son of Joash went home and lived in his house.
- 29 Jerub-Baal son of Joash went back home to live.
- 30 Gideon had seventy sons. He fathered them all--he had a lot of wives!
- 30 He had seventy sons of his own, for he had many wives.
- 31 His concubine, the one at Shechem, also bore him a son. He named him Abimelech.

- 31 His concubine, who lived in Shechem, also bore him a son, whom he named Abimelech.
- 32 Gideon son of Joash died at a good old age. He was buried in the tomb of his father Joash at Ophrah of the Abiezrites.
- 32 Gideon son of Joash died at a good old age and was buried in the tomb of his father Joash in Ophrah of the Abiezrites.
- 33 Gideon was hardly cool in the tomb when the People of Israel had gotten off track and were prostituting themselves to Baal--they made Baal-of-the-Covenant their god.
- 33 No sooner had Gideon died than the Israelites again prostituted themselves to the Baals. They set up Baal-Berith as their god and
- 34 The People of Israel forgot all about GOD, their God, who had saved them from all their enemies who had hemmed them in.
- 34 did not remember the LORD their God, who had rescued them from the hands of all their enemies on every side.
- 35 And they didn't keep faith with the family of Jerub-Baal (Gideon), honoring all the good he had done for Israel.
- 35 They also failed to show kindness to the family of Jerub-Baal (that is, Gideon) for all the good things he had done for them.

Judges 9

MSG

NIV

- 1 Abimelech son of Jerub-Baal went to Shechem to his uncles and all his mother's relatives and said to them,
- 1 Abimelech son of Jerub-Baal went to his mother's brothers in Shechem and said to them and to all his mother's clan,
- 2 "Ask all the leading men of Shechem, 'What do you think is best, that seventy men rule you--all those sons of Jerub-Baal--or that one man rule? You'll remember that I am your own flesh and blood.'"
- 2 Ask all the citizens of Shechem, 'Which is better for you: to have all seventy of Jerub-Baal's sons rule over you, or just one man?' Remember, I am your flesh and blood.
- 3 His mother's relatives reported the proposal to the leaders of Shechem. They were inclined to take Abimelech. "Because," they said, "he is, after

all, one of us."

- 3 When the brothers repeated all this to the citizens of Shechem, they were inclined to follow Abimelech, for they said, "He is our brother."
- 4 They gave him seventy silver pieces from the shrine of Baal-of-the-Covenant. With the money he hired some reckless riff-raff soldiers and they followed along after him.
- 4 They gave him seventy shekels of silver from the temple of Baal-Berith, and Abimelech used it to hire reckless adventurers, who became his followers.
- 5 He went to his father's house in Ophrah and killed his half brothers, the sons of Jerub-Baal--seventy men! And on one stone! The youngest, Jotham son of Jerub-Baal, managed to hide, the only survivor.
- 5 He went to his father's home in Ophrah and on one stone murdered his seventy brothers, the sons of Jerub-Baal. But Jotham, the youngest son of Jerub-Baal, escaped by hiding.
- 6 Then all the leaders of Shechem and Beth Millo gathered at the Oak by the Standing Stone at Shechem and crowned Abimelech king.
- 6 Then all the citizens of Shechem and Beth Millo gathered beside the great tree at the pillar in Shechem to crown Abimelech king.
- 7 When this was all told to Jotham, he climbed to the top of Mount Gerizim, raised his voice, and shouted: Listen to me, leaders of Shechem. And let God listen to you!
- 7 When Jotham was told about this, he climbed up on the top of Mount Gerizim and shouted to them, "Listen to me, citizens of Shechem, so that God may listen to you.
- 8 The trees set out one day to anoint a king for themselves. They said to Olive Tree, "Rule over us."
- 8 One day the trees went out to anoint a king for themselves. They said to the olive tree, 'Be our king.'
- 9 But Olive Tree told them, "Am I no longer good for making oil That gives glory to gods and men, and to be demoted to waving over trees?"
- 9 But the olive tree answered, 'Should I give up my oil, by which both gods and men are honored, to hold sway over the trees?'
- 10 The trees then said to Fig Tree, "You come and rule over us."
- 10 Next, the trees said to the fig tree, 'Come and be our king.'

- 11 But Fig Tree said to them, "Am I no longer good for making sweets, My mouthwatering sweet fruits, and to be demoted to waving over trees?"
- 11 But the fig tree replied, 'Should I give up my fruit, so good and sweet, to hold sway over the trees?'
- 12 The trees then said to Vine, "You come and rule over us."
- 12 Then the trees said to the vine, 'Come and be our king.'
- 13 But Vine said to them, "Am I no longer good for making wine, Wine that cheers gods and men, and to be demoted to waving over trees?"
- 13 But the vine answered, 'Should I give up my wine, which cheers both gods and men, to hold sway over the trees?'
- 14 All the trees then said to Tumbleweed, "You come and reign over us."
- 14 Finally all the trees said to the thornbush, 'Come and be our king.'
- 15 But Tumbleweed said to the trees: "If you're serious about making me your king, Come and find shelter in my shade. But if not, let fire shoot from Tumbleweed and burn down the cedars of Lebanon!"
- 15 The thornbush said to the trees, 'If you really want to anoint me king over you, come and take refuge in my shade; but if not, then let fire come out of the thornbush and consume the cedars of Lebanon!'
- 16 "Now listen: Do you think you did a right and honorable thing when you made Abimelech king? Do you think you treated Jerub-Baal and his family well, did for him what he deserved?
- 16 Now if you have acted honorably and in good faith when you made Abimelech king, and if you have been fair to Jerub-Baal and his family, and if you have treated him as he deserves--
- 17 My father fought for you, risked his own life, and rescued you from Midian's tyranny,
- 17 and to think that my father fought for you, risked his life to rescue you from the hand of Midian
- 18 and you have, just now, betrayed him. You massacred his sons--seventy men on a single stone! You made Abimelech, the son by his maidservant, king over Shechem's leaders because he's your relative.
- 18 (but today you have revolted against my father's family, murdered his seventy sons on a single stone, and made Abimelech, the son of his slave girl, king over the citizens of Shechem because he is your brother)--
- 19 If you think that this is an honest day's work, this way you have treated Jerub-Baal today, then enjoy Abimelech and let him enjoy you.

- 19 if then you have acted honorably and in good faith toward Jerub-Baal and his family today, may Abimelech be your joy, and may you be his, too!
- 20 But if not, let fire break from Abimelech and burn up the leaders of Shechem and Beth Millo. And let fire break from the leaders of Shechem and Beth Millo and burn up Abimelech."
- 20 But if you have not, let fire come out from Abimelech and consume you, citizens of Shechem and Beth Millo, and let fire come out from you, citizens of Shechem and Beth Millo, and consume Abimelech!"
- 21 And Jotham fled. He ran for his life. He went to Beer and settled down there, because he was afraid of his brother Abimelech.
- 21 Then Jotham fled, escaping to Beer, and he lived there because he was afraid of his brother Abimelech.
- 22 Abimelech ruled over Israel for three years.
- 22 After Abimelech had governed Israel three years,
- 23 Then God brought bad blood between Abimelech and Shechem's leaders, who now worked treacherously behind his back.
- 23 God sent an evil spirit between Abimelech and the citizens of Shechem, who acted treacherously against Abimelech.
- 24 Violence boomeranged: The murderous violence that killed the seventy brothers, the sons of Jerub-Baal, was now loose among Abimelech and Shechem's leaders, who had supported the violence.
- 24 God did this in order that the crime against Jerub-Baal's seventy sons, the shedding of their blood, might be avenged on their brother Abimelech and on the citizens of Shechem, who had helped him murder his brothers.
- 25 To undermine Abimelech, Shechem's leaders put men in ambush on the mountain passes who robbed travelers on those roads. And Abimelech was told.
- 25 In opposition to him these citizens of Shechem set men on the hilltops to ambush and rob everyone who passed by, and this was reported to Abimelech.
- 26 At that time Gaal son of Ebed arrived with his relatives and moved into Shechem. The leaders of Shechem trusted him.
- 26 Now Gaal son of Ebed moved with his brothers into Shechem, and its citizens put their confidence in him.

- 27 One day they went out into the fields, gathered grapes in the vineyards, and trod them in the winepress. Then they held a celebration in their god's temple, a feast, eating and drinking. And then they started putting down Abimelech.
- 27 After they had gone out into the fields and gathered the grapes and trodden them, they held a festival in the temple of their god. While they were eating and drinking, they cursed Abimelech.
- 28 Gaal son of Ebed said, "Who is this Abimelech? And who are we Shechemites to take orders from him? Isn't he the son of Jerub-Baal, and isn't this his henchman Zebul? We belong to the race of Hamor and bear the noble name of Shechem. Why should we be toadies of Abimelech?
- 28 Then Gaal son of Ebed said, "Who is Abimelech, and who is Shechem, that we should be subject to him? Isn't he Jerub-Baal's son, and isn't Zebul his deputy? Serve the men of Hamor, Shechem's father! Why should we serve Abimelech?
- 29 If I were in charge of this people, the first thing I'd do is get rid of Abimelech! I'd say, 'Show me your stuff, Abimelech--let's see who's boss here!'"
- 29 If only this people were under my command! Then I would get rid of him. I would say to Abimelech, 'Call out your whole army!' "
- 30 Zebul, governor of the city, heard what Gaal son of Ebed was saying and got angry.
- 30 When Zebul the governor of the city heard what Gaal son of Ebed said, he was very angry.
- 31 Secretly he sent messengers to Abimelech with the message, "Gaal son of Ebed and his relatives have come to Shechem and are stirring up trouble against you.
- 31 Under cover he sent messengers to Abimelech, saying, "Gaal son of Ebed and his brothers have come to Shechem and are stirring up the city against you.
- 32 Here's what you do: Tonight bring your troops and wait in ambush in the field.
- 32 Now then, during the night you and your men should come and lie in wait in the fields.
- 33 In the morning, as soon as the sun breaks, get moving and charge the city. Gaal and his troops will come out to you, and you'll know what to

do next."

33 In the morning at sunrise, advance against the city. When Gaal and his men come out against you, do whatever your hand finds to do."

34 Abimelech and his troops, four companies of them, went up that night and waited in ambush approaching Shechem.

34 So Abimelech and all his troops set out by night and took up concealed positions near Shechem in four companies.

35 Gaal son of Ebed had gotten up and was standing in the city gate. Abimelech and his troops left their cover.

35 Now Gaal son of Ebed had gone out and was standing at the entrance to the city gate just as Abimelech and his soldiers came out from their hiding place.

36 When Gaal saw them he said to Zebul, "Look at that, people coming down from the tops of the mountains!" Zebul said, "That's nothing but mountain shadows; they just look like men." Gaal kept chattering away.

36 When Gaal saw them, he said to Zebul, "Look, people are coming down from the tops of the mountains!" Zebul replied, "You mistake the shadows of the mountains for men."

37 Then he said again, "Look at the troops coming down off Tabbur-erez (the Navel of the World)--and one company coming straight from the Oracle Oak."

37 But Gaal spoke up again: "Look, people are coming down from the center of the land, and a company is coming from the direction of the soothsayers' tree."

38 Zebul said, "Where is that big mouth of yours now? You who said, 'And who is Abimelech that we should take orders from him?' Well, there he is with the troops you ridiculed. Here's your chance. Fight away!"

38 Then Zebul said to him, "Where is your big talk now, you who said, 'Who is Abimelech that we should be subject to him?' Aren't these the men you ridiculed? Go out and fight them!"

39 Gaal went out, backed by the leaders of Shechem, and did battle with Abimelech.

39 So Gaal led out the citizens of Shechem and fought Abimelech.

40 Abimelech chased him, and Gaal turned tail and ran. Many fell wounded, right up to the city gate.

- 40 Abimelech chased him, and many fell wounded in the flight--all the way to the entrance to the gate.
- 41 Abimelech set up his field headquarters at Arumah while Zebul kept Gaal and his relatives out of Shechem.
- 41 Abimelech stayed in Arumah, and Zebul drove Gaal and his brothers out of Shechem.
- 42 The next day the people went out to the fields. This was reported to Abimelech.
- 42 The next day the people of Shechem went out to the fields, and this was reported to Abimelech.
- 43 He took his troops, divided them into three companies, and placed them in ambush in the fields. When he saw that the people were well out in the open, he sprang up and attacked them.
- 43 So he took his men, divided them into three companies and set an ambush in the fields. When he saw the people coming out of the city, he rose to attack them.
- 44 Abimelech and the company with him charged ahead and took control of the entrance to the city gate; the other two companies chased down those who were in the open fields and killed them.
- 44 Abimelech and the companies with him rushed forward to a position at the entrance to the city gate. Then two companies rushed upon those in the fields and struck them down.
- 45 Abimelech fought at the city all that day. He captured the city and massacred everyone in it. He leveled the city to the ground, then sowed it with salt.
- 45 All that day Abimelech pressed his attack against the city until he had captured it and killed its people. Then he destroyed the city and scattered salt over it.
- 46 When the leaders connected with Shechem's Tower heard this, they went into the fortified God-of-the-Covenant temple.
- 46 On hearing this, the citizens in the tower of Shechem went into the stronghold of the temple of El-Berith.
- 47 This was reported to Abimelech that the Shechem's Tower bunch were gathered together.
- 47 When Abimelech heard that they had assembled there,

- 48 He and his troops climbed Mount Zalmon (Dark Mountain). Abimelech took his ax and chopped a bundle of firewood, picked it up, and put it on his shoulder. He said to his troops, "Do what you've seen me do, and quickly."
- 48 he and all his men went up Mount Zalmon. He took an ax and cut off some branches, which he lifted to his shoulders. He ordered the men with him, "Quick! Do what you have seen me do!"
- 49 So each of his men cut his own bundle. They followed Abimelech, piled their bundles against the Tower fortifications, and set the whole structure on fire. Everyone in Shechem's Tower died, about a thousand men and women.
- 49 So all the men cut branches and followed Abimelech. They piled them against the stronghold and set it on fire over the people inside. So all the people in the tower of Shechem, about a thousand men and women, also died.
- 50 Abimelech went on to Thebez. He camped at Thebez and captured it.
- 50 Next Abimelech went to Thebez and besieged it and captured it.
- 51 The Tower-of-Strength stood in the middle of the city; all the men and women of the city along with the city's leaders had fled there and locked themselves in. They were up on the tower roof.
- 51 Inside the city, however, was a strong tower, to which all the men and women--all the people of the city--fled. They locked themselves in and climbed up on the tower roof.
- 52 Abimelech got as far as the tower and assaulted it. He came up to the tower door to set it on fire.
- 52 Abimelech went to the tower and stormed it. But as he approached the entrance to the tower to set it on fire,
- 53 Just then some woman dropped an upper millstone on his head and crushed his skull.
- 53 a woman dropped an upper millstone on his head and cracked his skull.
- 54 He called urgently to his young armor-bearer and said, "Draw your sword and kill me so they can't say of me, 'A woman killed him.'" His armor bearer drove in his sword, and Abimelech died.
- 54 Hurriedly he called to his armor-bearer, "Draw your sword and kill me, so that they can't say, 'A woman killed him.' " So his servant ran him through, and he died.

- 55 When the Israelites saw that Abimelech was dead, they went home.
- 55 When the Israelites saw that Abimelech was dead, they went home.
- 56 God avenged the evil Abimelech had done to his father, murdering his seventy brothers.
- 56 Thus God repaid the wickedness that Abimelech had done to his father by murdering his seventy brothers.
- 57 And God brought down on the heads of the men of Shechem all the evil that they had done, the curse of Jotham son of Jerub-Baal.
- 57 God also made the men of Shechem pay for all their wickedness. The curse of Jotham son of Jerub-Baal came on them.

Judges 10

MSG

NIV

- 1 Tola son of Puah, the son of Dodo, was next after Abimelech. He rose to the occasion to save Israel. He was a man of Issachar. He lived in Shamir in the hill country of Ephraim.
- 1 After the time of Abimelech a man of Issachar, Tola son of Puah, the son of Dodo, rose to save Israel. He lived in Shamir, in the hill country of Ephraim.
- 2 He judged Israel for twenty-three years and then died and was buried at Shamir.
- 2 He led Israel twenty-three years; then he died, and was buried in Shamir.
- 3 After him, Jair the Gileadite stepped into leadership. He judged Israel for twenty-two years.
- 3 He was followed by Jair of Gilead, who led Israel twenty- two years.
- 4 He had thirty sons who rode on thirty donkeys and had thirty towns in Gilead. The towns are still called Jair's Villages.
- 4 He had thirty sons, who rode thirty donkeys. They controlled thirty towns in Gilead, which to this day are called Havvoth Jair.
- 5 Jair died and was buried in Kamon.
- 5 When Jair died, he was buried in Kamon.
- 6 And then the People of Israel went back to doing evil in GOD's sight. They worshiped the Baal gods and Ashtoreth goddesses: gods of Aram,

- Sidon, and Moab; gods of the Ammonites and the Philistines. They just walked off and left GOD, quit worshiping him.
- 6 Again the Israelites did evil in the eyes of the LORD. They served the Baals and the Ashtoreths, and the gods of Aram, the gods of Sidon, the gods of Moab, the gods of the Ammonites and the gods of the Philistines. And because the Israelites forsook the LORD and no longer served him,
- 7 And GOD exploded in hot anger at Israel and sold them off to the Philistines and Ammonites, who,
- 7 he became angry with them. He sold them into the hands of the Philistines and the Ammonites,
- 8 beginning that year, bullied and battered the People of Israel mercilessly. For eighteen years they had them under their thumb, all the People of Israel who lived east of the Jordan in the Amorite country of Gilead.
- 8 who that year shattered and crushed them. For eighteen years they oppressed all the Israelites on the east side of the Jordan in Gilead, the land of the Amorites.
- 9 Then the Ammonites crossed the Jordan to go to war also against Judah, Benjamin, and Ephraim. Israel was in a bad way!
- 9 The Ammonites also crossed the Jordan to fight against Judah, Benjamin and the house of Ephraim; and Israel was in great distress.
- 10 The People of Israel cried out to GOD for help: "We've sinned against you! We left our God and worshiped the Baal gods!"
- 10 Then the Israelites cried out to the LORD, "We have sinned against you, forsaking our God and serving the Baals."
- 11 GOD answered the People of Israel: "When the Egyptians, Amorites, Ammonites, Philistines, Sidonians--
- 11 The LORD replied, "When the Egyptians, the Amorites, the Ammonites, the Philistines,
- 12 even Amalek and Midian!--oppressed you and you cried out to me for help, I saved you from them.
- 12 the Sidonians, the Amalekites and the Maonites oppressed you and you cried to me for help, did I not save you from their hands?
- 13 And now you've gone off and betrayed me, worshiping other gods. I'm not saving you anymore.

- 13 But you have forsaken me and served other gods, so I will no longer save you.
- 14 Go ahead! Cry out for help to the gods you've chosen--let them get you out of the mess you're in!"
- 14 Go and cry out to the gods you have chosen. Let them save you when you are in trouble!"
- 15 The People of Israel said to GOD: "We've sinned. Do to us whatever you think best, but please, get us out of this!"
- 15 But the Israelites said to the LORD, "We have sinned. Do with us whatever you think best, but please rescue us now."
- 16 Then they cleaned house of the foreign gods and worshiped only GOD. And GOD took Israel's troubles to heart.
- 16 Then they got rid of the foreign gods among them and served the LORD. And he could bear Israel's misery no longer.
- 17 The Ammonites prepared for war, setting camp in Gilead. The People of Israel set their rival camp in Mizpah.
- 17 When the Ammonites were called to arms and camped in Gilead, the Israelites assembled and camped at Mizpah.
- 18 The leaders in Gilead said, "Who will stand up for us against the Ammonites? We'll make him head over everyone in Gilead!"
- 18 The leaders of the people of Gilead said to each other, "Whoever will launch the attack against the Ammonites will be the head of all those living in Gilead."

Judges 11

MSG

NIV

- 1 Jephthah the Gileadite was one tough warrior. He was the son of a whore, but Gilead was his father.
- 1 Jephthah the Gileadite was a mighty warrior. His father was Gilead; his mother was a prostitute.
- 2 Meanwhile Gilead's legal wife had given him other sons, and when they grew up, his wife's sons threw Jephthah out. They told him: "You're not getting any of our family inheritance--you're the son of another woman."

- 2 Gilead's wife also bore him sons, and when they were grown up, they drove Jephthah away. "You are not going to get any inheritance in our family," they said, "because you are the son of another woman."
- 3 So Jephthah fled from his brothers and went to live in the land of Tob. Some riff-raff joined him and went around with him.
- 3 So Jephthah fled from his brothers and settled in the land of Tob, where a group of adventurers gathered around him and followed him.
- 4 Some time passed. And then the Ammonites started fighting Israel.
- 4 Some time later, when the Ammonites made war on Israel,
- 5 With the Ammonites at war with them, the elders of Gilead went to get Jephthah from the land of Tob.
- 5 the elders of Gilead went to get Jephthah from the land of Tob.
- 6 They said to Jephthah: "Come. Be our general and we'll fight the Ammonites."
- 6 Come, they said, "be our commander, so we can fight the Ammonites."
- 7 But Jephthah said to the elders of Gilead: "But you hate me. You kicked me out of my family home. So why are you coming to me now? Because you are in trouble. Right?"
- 7 Jephthah said to them, "Didn't you hate me and drive me from my father's house? Why do you come to me now, when you're in trouble?"
- 8 The elders of Gilead replied, "That's it exactly. We've come to you to get you to go with us and fight the Ammonites. You'll be the head of all of us, all the Gileadites."
- 8 The elders of Gilead said to him, "Nevertheless, we are turning to you now; come with us to fight the Ammonites, and you will be our head over all who live in Gilead."
- 9 Jephthah addressed the elders of Gilead, "So if you bring me back home to fight the Ammonites and GOD gives them to me, I'll be your head--is that right?"
- 9 Jephthah answered, "Suppose you take me back to fight the Ammonites and the LORD gives them to me--will I really be your head?"
- 10 They said, "GOD is witness between us; whatever you say, we'll do."
- 10 The elders of Gilead replied, "The LORD is our witness; we will certainly do as you say."
- 11 Jephthah went along with the elders of Gilead. The people made him their top man and general. And Jephthah repeated what he had said

- before GOD at Mizpah.
- 11 So Jephthah went with the elders of Gilead, and the people made him head and commander over them. And he repeated all his words before the LORD in Mizpah.
- 12 Then Jephthah sent messengers to the king of the Ammonites with a message: "What's going on here that you have come into my country picking a fight?"
- 12 Then Jephthah sent messengers to the Ammonite king with the question: "What do you have against us that you have attacked our country?"
- 13 The king of the Ammonites told Jephthah's messengers: "Because Israel took my land when they came up out of Egypt--from the Arnon all the way to the Jabbok and to the Jordan. Give it back peaceably and I'll go."
- 13 The king of the Ammonites answered Jephthah's messengers, "When Israel came up out of Egypt, they took away my land from the Arnon to the Jabbok, all the way to the Jordan. Now give it back peaceably."
- 14 Jephthah again sent messengers to the king of the Ammonites with the message:
- 14 Jephthah sent back messengers to the Ammonite king,
- 15 "Jephthah's word: Israel took no Moabite land and no Ammonite land.
- 15 saying: "This is what Jephthah says: Israel did not take the land of Moab or the land of the Ammonites.
- 16 When they came up from Egypt, Israel went through the desert as far as the Red Sea, arriving at Kadesh.
- 16 But when they came up out of Egypt, Israel went through the desert to the Red Sea and on to Kadesh.
- 17 There Israel sent messengers to the king of Edom saying, 'Let us pass through your land, please.' But the king of Edom wouldn't let them. Israel also requested permission from the king of Moab, but he wouldn't let them cross either. They were stopped in their tracks at Kadesh.
- 17 Then Israel sent messengers to the king of Edom, saying, 'Give us permission to go through your country,' but the king of Edom would not listen. They sent also to the king of Moab, and he refused. So Israel stayed at Kadesh.
- 18 So they traveled across the desert and circled around the lands of Edom and Moab. They came out east of the land of Moab and set camp on the

other side of the Arnon--they didn't set foot in Moabite territory, for Arnon was the Moabite border.

18 Next they traveled through the desert, skirted the lands of Edom and Moab, passed along the eastern side of the country of Moab, and camped on the other side of the Arnon. They did not enter the territory of Moab, for the Arnon was its border.

19 Israel then sent messengers to Sihon king of the Amorites at Heshbon the capital. Israel asked, 'Let us pass, please, through your land on the way to our country.'

19 Then Israel sent messengers to Sihon king of the Amorites, who ruled in Heshbon, and said to him, 'Let us pass through your country to our own place.'

20 But Sihon didn't trust Israel to cut across his land; he got his entire army together, set up camp at Jahaz, and fought Israel.

20 Sihon, however, did not trust Israel to pass through his territory. He mustered all his men and encamped at Jahaz and fought with Israel.

21 But GOD, the God of Israel, gave Sihon and all his troops to Israel. Israel defeated them. Israel took all the Amorite land,

21 Then the LORD, the God of Israel, gave Sihon and all his men into Israel's hands, and they defeated them. Israel took over all the land of the Amorites who lived in that country,

22 all Amorite land from Arnon to the Jabbok and from the desert to the Jordan.

22 capturing all of it from the Arnon to the Jabbok and from the desert to the Jordan.

23 It was GOD, the God of Israel, who pushed out the Amorites in favor of Israel; so who do you think you are to try to take it over?

23 Now since the LORD, the God of Israel, has driven the Amorites out before his people Israel, what right have you to take it over?

24 Why don't you just be satisfied with what your god Chemosh gives you and we'll settle for what GOD, our God, gives us?

24 Will you not take what your god Chemosh gives you? Likewise, whatever the LORD our God has given us, we will possess.

25 Do you think you're going to come off better than Balak son of Zippor, the king of Moab? Did he get anywhere in opposing Israel? Did he risk war?

- 25 Are you better than Balak son of Zippor, king of Moab? Did he ever quarrel with Israel or fight with them?
- 26 All this time--it's been three hundred years now!--that Israel has lived in Heshbon and its villages, in Aroer and its villages, and in all the towns along the Arnon, why didn't you try to snatch them away then?
- 26 For three hundred years Israel occupied Heshbon, Aroer, the surrounding settlements and all the towns along the Arnon. Why didn't you retake them during that time?
- 27 No, I haven't wronged you. But this is an evil thing that you are doing to me by starting a fight. Today GOD the Judge will decide between the People of Israel and the people of Ammon."
- 27 I have not wronged you, but you are doing me wrong by waging war against me. Let the LORD, the Judge, decide the dispute this day between the Israelites and the Ammonites."
- 28 But the king of the Ammonites refused to listen to a word that Jephthah had sent him.
- 28 The king of Ammon, however, paid no attention to the message Jephthah sent him.
- 29 GOD's Spirit came upon Jephthah. He went across Gilead and Manasseh, went through Mizpah of Gilead, and from there approached the Ammonites.
- 29 Then the Spirit of the LORD came upon Jephthah. He crossed Gilead and Manasseh, passed through Mizpah of Gilead, and from there he advanced against the Ammonites.
- 30 Jephthah made a vow before GOD: "If you give me a clear victory over the Ammonites,
- 30 And Jephthah made a vow to the LORD: "If you give the Ammonites into my hands,
- 31 then I'll give to GOD whatever comes out of the door of my house to meet me when I return in one piece from among the Ammonites--I'll offer it up in a sacrificial burnt offering."
- 31 whatever comes out of the door of my house to meet me when I return in triumph from the Ammonites will be the LORD's, and I will sacrifice it as a burnt offering."
- 32 Then Jephthah was off to fight the Ammonites. And GOD gave them to him.

- 32 Then Jephthah went over to fight the Ammonites, and the LORD gave them into his hands.
- 33 He beat them soundly, all the way from Aroer to the area around Minnith as far as Abel Keramim--twenty cities! A massacre! Ammonites brought to their knees by the People of Israel.
- 33 He devastated twenty towns from Aroer to the vicinity of Minnith, as far as Abel Keramim. Thus Israel subdued Ammon.
- 34 Jephthah came home to Mizpah. His daughter ran from the house to welcome him home--dancing to tambourines! She was his only child. He had no son or daughter except her.
- 34 When Jephthah returned to his home in Mizpah, who should come out to meet him but his daughter, dancing to the sound of tambourines! She was an only child. Except for her he had neither son nor daughter.
- 35 When he realized who it was, he ripped his clothes, saying, "Ah, dearest daughter--I'm dirt. I'm despicable. My heart is torn to shreds. I made a vow to GOD and I can't take it back!"
- 35 When he saw her, he tore his clothes and cried, "Oh! My daughter! You have made me miserable and wretched, because I have made a vow to the LORD that I cannot break."
- 36 She said, "Dear father, if you made a vow to GOD, do to me what you vowed; GOD did his part and saved you from your Ammonite enemies."
- 36 My father, she replied, "you have given your word to the LORD. Do to me just as you promised, now that the LORD has avenged you of your enemies, the Ammonites.
- 37 And then she said to her father, "But let this one thing be done for me. Give me two months to wander through the hills and lament my virginity since I will never marry, I and my dear friends."
- 37 But grant me this one request," she said. "Give me two months to roam the hills and weep with my friends, because I will never marry."
- 38 "Oh yes, go," he said. He sent her off for two months. She and her dear girlfriends went among the hills, lamenting that she would never marry.
- 38 You may go, he said. And he let her go for two months. She and the girls went into the hills and wept because she would never marry.
- 39 At the end of the two months, she came back to her father. He fulfilled the vow with her that he had made. She had never slept with a man. It became a custom in Israel

39 After the two months, she returned to her father and he did to her as he had vowed. And she was a virgin. From this comes the Israelite custom
40 that for four days every year the young women of Israel went out to mourn for the daughter of Jephthah the Gileadite.
40 that each year the young women of Israel go out for four days to commemorate the daughter of Jephthah the Gileadite.

Judges 12

MSG

NIV

- 1 The men of Ephraim mustered their troops, crossed to Zaphon, and said to Jephthah, "Why did you go out to fight the Ammonites without letting us go with you? We're going to burn your house down on you!"
- 1 The men of Ephraim called out their forces, crossed over to Zaphon and said to Jephthah, "Why did you go to fight the Ammonites without calling us to go with you? We're going to burn down your house over your head."
- 2 Jephthah said, "I and my people had our hands full negotiating with the Ammonites. And I did call to you for help but you ignored me.
- 2 Jephthah answered, "I and my people were engaged in a great struggle with the Ammonites, and although I called, you didn't save me out of their hands.
- 3 When I saw that you weren't coming, I took my life in my hands and confronted the Ammonites myself. And GOD gave them to me! So why did you show up here today? Are you spoiling for a fight with me?"
- 3 When I saw that you wouldn't help, I took my life in my hands and crossed over to fight the Ammonites, and the LORD gave me the victory over them. Now why have you come up today to fight me?"
- 4 So Jephthah got his Gilead troops together and fought Ephraim. And the men of Gilead hit them hard because they were saying, "Gileadites are nothing but half-breeds and rejects from Ephraim and Manasseh."
- 4 Jephthah then called together the men of Gilead and fought against Ephraim. The Gileadites struck them down because the Ephraimites had said, "You Gileadites are renegades from Ephraim and Manasseh."

- 5 Gilead captured the fords of the Jordan at the crossing to Ephraim. If an Ephraimite fugitive said, "Let me cross," the men of Gilead would ask, "Are you an Ephraimite?" and he would say, "No."
- 5 The Gileadites captured the fords of the Jordan leading to Ephraim, and whenever a survivor of Ephraim said, "Let me cross over," the men of Gilead asked him, "Are you an Ephraimite?" If he replied, "No,"
- 6 And they would say, "Say, 'Shibboleth.'" But he would always say, "Sibboleth"--he couldn't say it right. Then they would grab him and kill him there at the fords of the Jordan. Forty-two Ephraimite divisions were killed on that occasion.
- 6 they said, "All right, say 'Shibboleth.' " If he said, "Sibboleth," because he could not pronounce the word correctly, they seized him and killed him at the fords of the Jordan. Forty-two thousand Ephraimites were killed at that time.
- 7 Jephthah judged Israel six years. Jephthah the Gileadite died and was buried in his city, Mizpah of Gilead.
- 7 Jephthah led Israel six years. Then Jephthah the Gileadite died, and was buried in a town in Gilead.
- 8 After him, Ibzan of Bethlehem judged Israel.
- 8 After him, Ibzan of Bethlehem led Israel.
- 9 He had thirty sons and thirty daughters. He gave his daughters in marriage outside his clan and brought in thirty daughters-in-law from the outside for his sons.
- 9 He had thirty sons and thirty daughters. He gave his daughters away in marriage to those outside his clan, and for his sons he brought in thirty young women as wives from outside his clan. Ibzan led Israel seven years.
- 10 He judged Israel seven years. Ibzan died and was buried in Bethlehem.
- 10 Then Ibzan died, and was buried in Bethlehem.
- 11 After him, Elon the Zebulunite judged Israel. He judged Israel ten years.
- 11 After him, Elon the Zebulunite led Israel ten years.
- 12 Elon the Zebulunite died and was buried at Aijalon in the land of Zebulun.
- 12 Then Elon died, and was buried in Aijalon in the land of Zebulun.
- 13 After him, Abdon son of Hillel the Pirathonite judged Israel.
- 13 After him, Abdon son of Hillel, from Pirathon, led Israel.

- 14 He had forty sons and thirty grandsons who rode on seventy donkeys.
He judged Israel eight years.
- 14 He had forty sons and thirty grandsons, who rode on seventy donkeys.
He led Israel eight years.
- 15 Abdon son of Hillel the Pirathonite died and was buried at Pirathon in
the land of Ephraim in the Amalekite hill country.
- 15 Then Abdon son of Hillel died, and was buried at Pirathon in Ephraim,
in the hill country of the Amalekites.

Judges 13

MSG

NIV

- 1 And then the People of Israel were back at it again, doing what was evil
in GOD's sight. GOD put them under the domination of the Philistines
for forty years.
- 1 Again the Israelites did evil in the eyes of the LORD, so the LORD
delivered them into the hands of the Philistines for forty years.
- 2 At that time there was a man named Manoah from Zorah from the tribe
of Dan. His wife was barren and childless.
- 2 A certain man of Zorah, named Manoah, from the clan of the Danites,
had a wife who was sterile and remained childless.
- 3 The angel of God appeared to her and told her, "I know that you are
barren and childless, but you're going to become pregnant and bear a
son.
- 3 The angel of the LORD appeared to her and said, "You are sterile and
childless, but you are going to conceive and have a son.
- 4 But take much care: Drink no wine or beer; eat nothing ritually unclean.
- 4 Now see to it that you drink no wine or other fermented drink and that
you do not eat anything unclean,
- 5 You are, in fact, pregnant right now, carrying a son. No razor will touch
his head--the boy will be God's Nazirite from the moment of his birth.
He will launch the deliverance from Philistine oppression."
- 5 because you will conceive and give birth to a son. No razor may be used
on his head, because the boy is to be a Nazirite, set apart to God from

- birth, and he will begin the deliverance of Israel from the hands of the Philistines."
- 6 The woman went to her husband and said, "A man of God came to me. He looked like the angel of God--terror laced with glory! I didn't ask him where he was from and he didn't tell me his name,
- 6 Then the woman went to her husband and told him, "A man of God came to me. He looked like an angel of God, very awesome. I didn't ask him where he came from, and he didn't tell me his name.
- 7 but he told me, 'You're pregnant. You're going to give birth to a son. Don't drink any wine or beer and eat nothing ritually unclean. The boy will be God's Nazirite from the moment of birth to the day of his death.'"
- 7 But he said to me, 'You will conceive and give birth to a son. Now then, drink no wine or other fermented drink and do not eat anything unclean, because the boy will be a Nazirite of God from birth until the day of his death.' "
- 8 Manoah prayed to GOD: "Master, let the man of God you sent come to us again and teach us how to raise this boy who is to be born."
- 8 Then Manoah prayed to the LORD: "O Lord, I beg you, let the man of God you sent to us come again to teach us how to bring up the boy who is to be born."
- 9 God listened to Manoah. God's angel came again to the woman. She was sitting in the field; her husband Manoah wasn't there with her.
- 9 God heard Manoah, and the angel of God came again to the woman while she was out in the field; but her husband Manoah was not with her.
- 10 She jumped to her feet and ran and told her husband: "He's back! The man who came to me that day!"
- 10 The woman hurried to tell her husband, "He's here! The man who appeared to me the other day!"
- 11 Manoah got up and, following his wife, came to the man. He said to him, "Are you the man who spoke to my wife?" He said, "I am."
- 11 Manoah got up and followed his wife. When he came to the man, he said, "Are you the one who talked to my wife?" "I am," he said.
- 12 Manoah said, "So. When what you say comes true, what do you have to tell us about this boy and his work?"
- 12 So Manoah asked him, "When your words are fulfilled, what is to be the rule for the boy's life and work?"

- 13 The angel of God said to Manoah,
- 13 The angel of the LORD answered, "Your wife must do all that I have told her.
- 14 "Keep in mind everything I told the woman. Eat nothing that comes from the vine: Drink no wine or beer; eat no ritually unclean foods. She's to observe everything I commanded her."
- 14 She must not eat anything that comes from the grapevine, nor drink any wine or other fermented drink nor eat anything unclean. She must do everything I have commanded her."
- 15 Manoah said to the angel of God, "Please, stay with us a little longer; we'll prepare a meal for you--a young goat."
- 15 Manoah said to the angel of the LORD, "We would like you to stay until we prepare a young goat for you."
- 16 GOD's angel said to Manoah, "Even if I stay, I won't eat your food. But if you want to prepare a Whole-Burnt-Offering for GOD, go ahead--offer it!" Manoah had no idea that he was talking to the angel of God.
- 16 The angel of the LORD replied, "Even though you detain me, I will not eat any of your food. But if you prepare a burnt offering, offer it to the LORD." (Manoah did not realize that it was the angel of the LORD.)
- 17 Then Manoah asked the angel of God, "What's your name? When your words come true, we'd like to honor you."
- 17 Then Manoah inquired of the angel of the LORD, "What is your name, so that we may honor you when your word comes true?"
- 18 The angel of GOD said, "What's this? You ask for my name? You wouldn't understand--it's sheer wonder."
- 18 He replied, "Why do you ask my name? It is beyond understanding. "
- 19 So Manoah took the kid and the Grain-Offering and sacrificed them on a rock altar to GOD who works wonders.
- 19 Then Manoah took a young goat, together with the grain offering, and sacrificed it on a rock to the LORD. And the LORD did an amazing thing while Manoah and his wife watched:
- 20 As the flames leapt up from the altar to heaven, GOD's angel also ascended in the altar flames. When Manoah and his wife saw this, they fell facedown to the ground.
- 20 As the flame blazed up from the altar toward heaven, the angel of the LORD ascended in the flame. Seeing this, Manoah and his wife fell with

their faces to the ground.

- 21 Manoah and his wife never saw the angel of GOD again. Only then did Manoah realize that this was GOD's angel.
- 21 When the angel of the LORD did not show himself again to Manoah and his wife, Manoah realized that it was the angel of the LORD.
- 22 He said to his wife, "We're as good as dead! We've looked on God!"
- 22 We are doomed to die! he said to his wife. "We have seen God!"
- 23 But his wife said, "If GOD were planning to kill us, he wouldn't have accepted our Whole-Burnt-Offering and Grain-Offering, or revealed all these things to us--given us this birth announcement."
- 23 But his wife answered, "If the LORD had meant to kill us, he would not have accepted a burnt offering and grain offering from our hands, nor shown us all these things or now told us this."
- 24 The woman gave birth to a son. They named him Samson. The boy grew and GOD blessed him.
- 24 The woman gave birth to a boy and named him Samson. He grew and the LORD blessed him,
- 25 The Spirit of GOD began working in him while he was staying at a Danite camp between Zorah and Eshtaol.
- 25 and the Spirit of the LORD began to stir him while he was in Mahaneh Dan, between Zorah and Eshtaol.

Judges 14

MSG

NIV

- 1 Samson went down to Timnah. There in Timnah a woman caught his eye, a Philistine girl.
- 1 Samson went down to Timnah and saw there a young Philistine woman.
- 2 He came back and told his father and mother, "I saw a woman in Timnah, a Philistine girl; get her for me as my wife."
- 2 When he returned, he said to his father and mother, "I have seen a Philistine woman in Timnah; now get her for me as my wife."
- 3 His parents said to him, "Isn't there a woman among the girls in the neighborhood of our people? Do you have to go get a wife from the

- uncircumcised Philistines?" But Samson said to his father, "Get her for me. She's the one I want--she's the right one."
- 3 His father and mother replied, "Isn't there an acceptable woman among your relatives or among all our people? Must you go to the uncircumcised Philistines to get a wife?" But Samson said to his father, "Get her for me. She's the right one for me."
- 4 (His father and mother had no idea that GOD was behind this, that he was arranging an opportunity against the Philistines. At the time the Philistines lorded it over Israel.)
- 4 (His parents did not know that this was from the LORD, who was seeking an occasion to confront the Philistines; for at that time they were ruling over Israel.)
- 5 Samson went down to Timnah with his father and mother. When he got to the vineyards of Timnah, a young lion came at him, roaring.
- 5 Samson went down to Timnah together with his father and mother. As they approached the vineyards of Timnah, suddenly a young lion came roaring toward him.
- 6 The Spirit of GOD came on him powerfully and he ripped it open barehanded, like tearing a young goat. But he didn't tell his parents what he had done.
- 6 The Spirit of the LORD came upon him in power so that he tore the lion apart with his bare hands as he might have torn a young goat. But he told neither his father nor his mother what he had done.
- 7 Then he went on down and spoke to the woman. In Samson's eyes, she was the one.
- 7 Then he went down and talked with the woman, and he liked her.
- 8 Some days later when he came back to get her, he made a little detour to look at what was left of the lion. And there a wonder: a swarm of bees in the lion's carcass--and honey!
- 8 Some time later, when he went back to marry her, he turned aside to look at the lion's carcass. In it was a swarm of bees and some honey,
- 9 He scooped it up in his hands and kept going, eating as he went. He rejoined his father and mother and gave some to them and they ate. But he didn't tell them that he had scooped out the honey from the lion's carcass.

- 9 which he scooped out with his hands and ate as he went along. When he rejoined his parents, he gave them some, and they too ate it. But he did not tell them that he had taken the honey from the lion's carcass.
- 10 His father went on down to make arrangements with the woman, while Samson prepared a feast there. That's what the young men did in those days.
- 10 Now his father went down to see the woman. And Samson made a feast there, as was customary for bridegrooms.
- 11 Because the people were wary of him, they arranged for thirty friends to mingle with him.
- 11 When he appeared, he was given thirty companions.
- 12 Samson said to them: "Let me put a riddle to you. If you can figure it out during the seven days of the feast, I'll give you thirty linen garments and thirty changes of fine clothing.
- 12 Let me tell you a riddle, Samson said to them. "If you can give me the answer within the seven days of the feast, I will give you thirty linen garments and thirty sets of clothes.
- 13 But if you can't figure it out then you'll give me thirty linen garments and thirty changes of fine clothing." They said, "Put your riddle. Let's hear it."
- 13 If you can't tell me the answer, you must give me thirty linen garments and thirty sets of clothes." "Tell us your riddle," they said. "Let's hear it."
- 14 So he said, From the eater came something to eat, From the strong came something sweet. They couldn't figure it out. After three days they were still stumped.
- 14 He replied, "Out of the eater, something to eat; out of the strong, something sweet." For three days they could not give the answer.
- 15 On the fourth day they said to Samson's bride, "Worm the answer out of your husband or we'll burn you and your father's household. Have you invited us here to bankrupt us?"
- 15 On the fourth day, they said to Samson's wife, "Coax your husband into explaining the riddle for us, or we will burn you and your father's household to death. Did you invite us here to rob us?"
- 16 So Samson's bride turned on the tears, saying to him, "You hate me. You don't love me. You've told a riddle to my people but you won't even tell

- me the answer." He said, "I haven't told my own parents--why would I tell you?"
- 16 Then Samson's wife threw herself on him, sobbing, "You hate me! You don't really love me. You've given my people a riddle, but you haven't told me the answer." "I haven't even explained it to my father or mother," he replied, "so why should I explain it to you?"
- 17 But she turned on the tears all the seven days of the feast. On the seventh day, worn out by her nagging, he told her. Then she went and told it to her people.
- 17 She cried the whole seven days of the feast. So on the seventh day he finally told her, because she continued to press him. She in turn explained the riddle to her people.
- 18 The men of the town came to him on the seventh day, just before sunset and said, What is sweeter than honey? What is stronger than a lion? And Samson said, If you hadn't plowed with my heifer, You wouldn't have found out my riddle.
- 18 Before sunset on the seventh day the men of the town said to him, "What is sweeter than honey? What is stronger than a lion?" Samson said to them, "If you had not plowed with my heifer, you would not have solved my riddle."
- 19 Then the Spirit of GOD came powerfully on him. He went down to Ashkelon and killed thirty of their men, stripped them, and gave their clothing to those who had solved the riddle. Stalking out, smoking with anger, he went home to his father's house.
- 19 Then the Spirit of the LORD came upon him in power. He went down to Ashkelon, struck down thirty of their men, stripped them of their belongings and gave their clothes to those who had explained the riddle. Burning with anger, he went up to his father's house.
- 20 Samson's bride became the wife of the best man at his wedding.
- 20 And Samson's wife was given to the friend who had attended him at his wedding.

Judges 15

MSG

NIV

- 1 Later on--it was during the wheat harvest--Samson visited his bride, bringing a young goat. He said, "Let me see my wife--show me her bedroom." But her father wouldn't let him in.
- 1 Later on, at the time of wheat harvest, Samson took a young goat and went to visit his wife. He said, "I'm going to my wife's room." But her father would not let him go in.
- 2 He said, "I concluded that by now you hated her with a passion, so I gave her to your best man. But her little sister is even more beautiful. Why not take her instead?"
- 2 I was so sure you thoroughly hated her, he said, "that I gave her to your friend. Isn't her younger sister more attractive? Take her instead."
- 3 Samson said, "That does it. This time when I wreak havoc on the Philistines, I'm blameless."
- 3 Samson said to them, "This time I have a right to get even with the Philistines; I will really harm them."
- 4 Samson then went out and caught three hundred jackals. He lashed the jackals' tails together in pairs and tied a torch between each pair of tails.
- 4 So he went out and caught three hundred foxes and tied them tail to tail in pairs. He then fastened a torch to every pair of tails,
- 5 He then set fire to the torches and let them loose in the Philistine fields of ripe grain. Everything burned, both stacked and standing grain, vineyards and olive orchards--everything.
- 5 lit the torches and let the foxes loose in the standing grain of the Philistines. He burned up the shocks and standing grain, together with the vineyards and olive groves.
- 6 The Philistines said, "Who did this?" They were told, "Samson, son-in-law of the Timnite who took his bride and gave her to his best man." The Philistines went up and burned both her and her father to death.
- 6 When the Philistines asked, "Who did this?" they were told, "Samson, the Timnite's son-in-law, because his wife was given to his friend." So the Philistines went up and burned her and her father to death.
- 7 Samson then said, "If this is the way you're going to act, I swear I'll get even with you. And I'm not quitting till the job's done!"
- 7 Samson said to them, "Since you've acted like this, I won't stop until I get my revenge on you."

- 8 With that he tore into them, ripping them limb from limb--a huge slaughter. Then he went down and stayed in a cave at Etam Rock.
- 8 He attacked them viciously and slaughtered many of them. Then he went down and stayed in a cave in the rock of Etam.
- 9 The Philistines set out and made camp in Judah, preparing to attack Lehi (Jawbone).
- 9 The Philistines went up and camped in Judah, spreading out near Lehi.
- 10 When the men of Judah asked, "Why have you come up against us?" they said, "We're out to get Samson. We're going after Samson to do to him what he did to us."
- 10 The men of Judah asked, "Why have you come to fight us?" "We have come to take Samson prisoner," they answered, "to do to him as he did to us."
- 11 Three companies of men from Judah went down to the cave at Etam Rock and said to Samson, "Don't you realize that the Philistines already bully and lord it over us? So what's going on with you, making things even worse?" He said, "It was tit for tat. I only did to them what they did to me."
- 11 Then three thousand men from Judah went down to the cave in the rock of Etam and said to Samson, "Don't you realize that the Philistines are rulers over us? What have you done to us?" He answered, "I merely did to them what they did to me."
- 12 They said, "Well, we've come down here to tie you up and turn you over to the Philistines." Samson said, "Just promise not to hurt me."
- 12 They said to him, "We've come to tie you up and hand you over to the Philistines." Samson said, "Swear to me that you won't kill me yourselves."
- 13 "We promise," they said. "We will tie you up and surrender you to them but, believe us, we won't kill you." They proceeded to tie him with new ropes and led him up from the Rock.
- 13 Agreed, they answered. "We will only tie you up and hand you over to them. We will not kill you." So they bound him with two new ropes and led him up from the rock.
- 14 As he approached Lehi, the Philistines came to meet him, shouting in triumph. And then the Spirit of GOD came on him with great power. The

- ropes on his arms fell apart like flax on fire; the thongs slipped off his hands.
- 14 As he approached Lehi, the Philistines came toward him shouting. The Spirit of the LORD came upon him in power. The ropes on his arms became like charred flax, and the bindings dropped from his hands.
- 15 He spotted a fresh donkey jawbone, reached down and grabbed it, and with it killed the whole company.
- 15 Finding a fresh jawbone of a donkey, he grabbed it and struck down a thousand men.
- 16 And Samson said, With a donkey's jawbone I made heaps of donkeys of them. With a donkey's jawbone I killed an entire company.
- 16 Then Samson said, "With a donkey's jawbone I have made donkeys of them. With a donkey's jawbone I have killed a thousand men."
- 17 When he finished speaking, he threw away the jawbone. He named that place Ramath Lehi (Jawbone Hill).
- 17 When he finished speaking, he threw away the jawbone; and the place was called Ramath Lehi.
- 18 Now he was suddenly very thirsty. He called out to GOD, "You have given your servant this great victory. Are you going to abandon me to die of thirst and fall into the hands of the uncircumcised?"
- 18 Because he was very thirsty, he cried out to the LORD, "You have given your servant this great victory. Must I now die of thirst and fall into the hands of the uncircumcised?"
- 19 So God split open the rock basin in Lehi; water gushed out and Samson drank. His spirit revived--he was alive again! That's why it's called En Hakkore (Caller's Spring). It's still there at Lehi today.
- 19 Then God opened up the hollow place in Lehi, and water came out of it. When Samson drank, his strength returned and he revived. So the spring was called En Hakkore, and it is still there in Lehi.
- 20 Samson judged Israel for twenty years in the days of the Philistines.
- 20 Samson led Israel for twenty years in the days of the Philistines.

Judges 16

MSG

NIV

- 1 Samson went to Gaza and saw a prostitute. He went to her.
- 1 One day Samson went to Gaza, where he saw a prostitute. He went in to spend the night with her.
- 2 The news got around: "Samson's here." They gathered around in hiding, waiting all night for him at the city gate, quiet as mice, thinking, "At sunrise we'll kill him."
- 2 The people of Gaza were told, "Samson is here!" So they surrounded the place and lay in wait for him all night at the city gate. They made no move during the night, saying, "At dawn we'll kill him."
- 3 Samson was in bed with the woman until midnight. Then he got up, seized the doors of the city gate and the two gateposts, bolts and all, hefted them on his shoulder, and carried them to the top of the hill that faces Hebron.
- 3 But Samson lay there only until the middle of the night. Then he got up and took hold of the doors of the city gate, together with the two posts, and tore them loose, bar and all. He lifted them to his shoulders and carried them to the top of the hill that faces Hebron.
- 4 Some time later he fell in love with a woman in the Valley of Sorek (Grapes). Her name was Delilah.
- 4 Some time later, he fell in love with a woman in the Valley of Sorek whose name was Delilah.
- 5 The Philistine tyrants approached her and said, "Seduce him. Discover what's behind his great strength and how we can tie him up and humble him. Each man's company will give you a hundred shekels of silver."
- 5 The rulers of the Philistines went to her and said, "See if you can lure him into showing you the secret of his great strength and how we can overpower him so we may tie him up and subdue him. Each one of us will give you eleven hundred shekels of silver."
- 6 So Delilah said to Samson, "Tell me, dear, the secret of your great strength, and how you can be tied up and humbled."
- 6 So Delilah said to Samson, "Tell me the secret of your great strength and how you can be tied up and subdued."
- 7 Samson told her, "If they were to tie me up with seven bowstrings--the kind made from fresh animal tendons, not dried out--then I would become weak, just like anyone else."

- 7 Samson answered her, "If anyone ties me with seven fresh thongs that have not been dried, I'll become as weak as any other man."
- 8 The Philistine tyrants brought her seven bowstrings, not dried out, and she tied him up with them.
- 8 Then the rulers of the Philistines brought her seven fresh thongs that had not been dried, and she tied him with them.
- 9 The men were waiting in ambush in her room. Then she said, "The Philistines are on you, Samson!" He snapped the cords as though they were mere threads. The secret of his strength was still a secret.
- 9 With men hidden in the room, she called to him, "Samson, the Philistines are upon you!" But he snapped the thongs as easily as a piece of string snaps when it comes close to a flame. So the secret of his strength was not discovered.
- 10 Delilah said, "Come now, Samson--you're playing with me, making up stories. Be serious; tell me how you can be tied up."
- 10 Then Delilah said to Samson, "You have made a fool of me; you lied to me. Come now, tell me how you can be tied."
- 11 He told her, "If you were to tie me up tight with new ropes, ropes never used for work, then I would be helpless, just like anybody else."
- 11 He said, "If anyone ties me securely with new ropes that have never been used, I'll become as weak as any other man."
- 12 So Delilah got some new ropes and tied him up. She said, "The Philistines are on you, Samson!" The men were hidden in the next room. He snapped the ropes from his arms like threads.
- 12 So Delilah took new ropes and tied him with them. Then, with men hidden in the room, she called to him, "Samson, the Philistines are upon you!" But he snapped the ropes off his arms as if they were threads.
- 13 Delilah said to Samson, "You're still playing games with me, teasing me with lies. Tell me how you can be tied up." He said to her, "If you wove the seven braids of my hair into the fabric on the loom and drew it tight, then I would be as helpless as any other mortal." When she had him fast asleep, Delilah took the seven braids of his hair and wove them into the fabric on the loom
- 13 Delilah then said to Samson, "Until now, you have been making a fool of me and lying to me. Tell me how you can be tied." He replied, "If you weave the seven braids of my head into the fabric on the loom and

tighten it with the pin, I'll become as weak as any other man." So while he was sleeping, Delilah took the seven braids of his head, wove them into the fabric

14 and drew it tight. Then she said, "The Philistines are on you, Samson!"

He woke from his sleep and ripped loose from both the loom and fabric!

14 and tightened it with the pin. Again she called to him, "Samson, the Philistines are upon you!" He awoke from his sleep and pulled up the pin and the loom, with the fabric.

15 She said, "How can you say 'I love you' when you won't even trust me? Three times now you've toyed with me, like a cat with a mouse, refusing to tell me the secret of your great strength."

15 Then she said to him, "How can you say, 'I love you,' when you won't confide in me? This is the third time you have made a fool of me and haven't told me the secret of your great strength."

16 She kept at it day after day, nagging and tormenting him. Finally, he was fed up--he couldn't take another minute of it.

16 With such nagging she prodded him day after day until he was tired to death.

17 He spilled it. He told her, "A razor has never touched my head. I've been God's Nazirite from conception. If I were shaved, my strength would leave me; I would be as helpless as any other mortal."

17 So he told her everything. "No razor has ever been used on my head," he said, "because I have been a Nazirite set apart to God since birth. If my head were shaved, my strength would leave me, and I would become as weak as any other man."

18 When Delilah realized that he had told her his secret, she sent for the Philistine tyrants, telling them, "Come quickly--this time he's told me the truth." They came, bringing the bribe money.

18 When Delilah saw that he had told her everything, she sent word to the rulers of the Philistines, "Come back once more; he has told me everything." So the rulers of the Philistines returned with the silver in their hands.

19 When she got him to sleep, his head on her lap, she motioned to a man to cut off the seven braids of his hair. Immediately he began to grow weak. His strength drained from him.

- 19 Having put him to sleep on her lap, she called a man to shave off the seven braids of his hair, and so began to subdue him. And his strength left him.
- 20 Then she said, "The Philistines are on you, Samson!" He woke up, thinking, "I'll go out, like always, and shake free." He didn't realize that GOD had abandoned him.
- 20 Then she called, "Samson, the Philistines are upon you!" He awoke from his sleep and thought, "I'll go out as before and shake myself free." But he did not know that the LORD had left him.
- 21 The Philistines grabbed him, gouged out his eyes, and took him down to Gaza. They shackled him in irons and put him to the work of grinding in the prison.
- 21 Then the Philistines seized him, gouged out his eyes and took him down to Gaza. Binding him with bronze shackles, they set him to grinding in the prison.
- 22 But his hair, though cut off, began to grow again.
- 22 But the hair on his head began to grow again after it had been shaved.
- 23 The Philistine tyrants got together to offer a great sacrifice to their god Dagon. They celebrated, saying, Our god has given us Samson our enemy!
- 23 Now the rulers of the Philistines assembled to offer a great sacrifice to Dagon their god and to celebrate, saying, "Our god has delivered Samson, our enemy, into our hands."
- 24 And when the people saw him, they joined in, cheering their god, Our god has given Our enemy to us, The one who ravaged our country, Piling high the corpses among us.
- 24 When the people saw him, they praised their god, saying, "Our god has delivered our enemy into our hands, the one who laid waste our land and multiplied our slain."
- 25 Then this: Everyone was feeling high and someone said, "Get Samson! Let him show us his stuff!" They got Samson from the prison and he put on a show for them. They had him standing between the pillars.
- 25 While they were in high spirits, they shouted, "Bring out Samson to entertain us." So they called Samson out of the prison, and he performed for them. When they stood him among the pillars,

- 26 Samson said to the young man who was acting as his guide, "Put me where I can touch the pillars that hold up the temple so I can rest against them."
- 26 Samson said to the servant who held his hand, "Put me where I can feel the pillars that support the temple, so that I may lean against them."
- 27 The building was packed with men and women, including all the Philistine tyrants. And there were at least 3,000 in the stands watching Samson's performance.
- 27 Now the temple was crowded with men and women; all the rulers of the Philistines were there, and on the roof were about three thousand men and women watching Samson perform.
- 28 And Samson cried out to GOD: Master, GOD! Oh, please, look on me again, Oh, please, give strength yet once more. God! With one avenging blow let me be avenged On the Philistines for my two eyes!
- 28 Then Samson prayed to the LORD, "O Sovereign LORD, remember me. O God, please strengthen me just once more, and let me with one blow get revenge on the Philistines for my two eyes."
- 29 Then Samson reached out to the two central pillars that held up the building and pushed against them, one with his right arm, the other with his left.
- 29 Then Samson reached toward the two central pillars on which the temple stood. Bracing himself against them, his right hand on the one and his left hand on the other,
- 30 Saying, "Let me die with the Philistines," Samson pushed hard with all his might. The building crashed on the tyrants and all the people in it. He killed more people in his death than he had killed in his life.
- 30 Samson said, "Let me die with the Philistines!" Then he pushed with all his might, and down came the temple on the rulers and all the people in it. Thus he killed many more when he died than while he lived.
- 31 His brothers and all his relatives went down to get his body. They carried him back and buried him in the tomb of Manoah his father, between Zorah and Eshtaol. He judged Israel for twenty years.
- 31 Then his brothers and his father's whole family went down to get him. They brought him back and buried him between Zorah and Eshtaol in the tomb of Manoah his father. He had led Israel twenty years.

Judges 17

MSG

NIV

- 1 There was a man from the hill country of Ephraim named Micah.
- 1 Now a man named Micah from the hill country of Ephraim
- 2 He said to his mother, "Remember that 1,100 pieces of silver that were taken from you? I overheard you when you pronounced your curse. Well, I have the money; I stole it. But now I've brought it back to you." His mother said, "GOD bless you, my son!"
- 2 said to his mother, "The eleven hundred shekels of silver that were taken from you and about which I heard you utter a curse--I have that silver with me; I took it." Then his mother said, "The LORD bless you, my son!"
- 3 As he returned the 1,100 silver pieces to his mother, she said, "I had totally consecrated this money to GOD for my son to make a statue, a cast god."
- 3 When he returned the eleven hundred shekels of silver to his mother, she said, "I solemnly consecrate my silver to the LORD for my son to make a carved image and a cast idol. I will give it back to you."
- 4 Then she took 200 pieces of the silver and gave it to a sculptor and he cast them into the form of a god.
- 4 So he returned the silver to his mother, and she took two hundred shekels of silver and gave them to a silversmith, who made them into the image and the idol. And they were put in Micah's house.
- 5 This man, Micah, had a private chapel. He had made an ephod and some teraphim-idols and had ordained one of his sons to be his priest.
- 5 Now this man Micah had a shrine, and he made an ephod and some idols and installed one of his sons as his priest.
- 6 In those days there was no king in Israel. People did whatever they felt like doing.
- 6 In those days Israel had no king; everyone did as he saw fit.
- 7 Meanwhile there was a young man from Bethlehem in Judah and from a family of Judah. He was a Levite but was a stranger there.
- 7 A young Levite from Bethlehem in Judah, who had been living within the clan of Judah,

- 8 He left that town, Bethlehem in Judah, seeking his fortune. He got as far as the hill country of Ephraim and showed up at Micah's house.
- 8 left that town in search of some other place to stay. On his way he came to Micah's house in the hill country of Ephraim.
- 9 Micah asked him, "So where are you from?" He said, "I'm a Levite from Bethlehem in Judah. I'm on the road, looking for a place to settle down."
- 9 Micah asked him, "Where are you from?" "I'm a Levite from Bethlehem in Judah," he said, "and I'm looking for a place to stay."
- 10 Micah said, "Stay here with me. Be my father and priest. I'll pay you ten pieces of silver a year, whatever clothes you need, and your meals."
- 10 Then Micah said to him, "Live with me and be my father and priest, and I'll give you ten shekels of silver a year, your clothes and your food."
- 11 The Levite agreed and moved in with Micah. The young man fit right in and became one of the family.
- 11 So the Levite agreed to live with him, and the young man was to him like one of his sons.
- 12 Micah appointed the young Levite as his priest. This all took place in Micah's home.
- 12 Then Micah installed the Levite, and the young man became his priest and lived in his house.
- 13 Micah said, "Now I know that GOD will make things go well for me--why, I've got a Levite for a priest!"
- 13 And Micah said, "Now I know that the LORD will be good to me, since this Levite has become my priest."

Judges 18

MSG

NIV

- 1 In those days there was no king in Israel. But also in those days, the tribe of Dan was looking for a place to settle down. They hadn't yet occupied their plot among the tribes of Israel.
- 1 In those days Israel had no king. And in those days the tribe of the Danites was seeking a place of their own where they might settle, because they had not yet come into an inheritance among the tribes of Israel.

- 2 The Danites sent out five robust warriors from Zorah and Eshtaol to look over the land and see what was out there suitable for their families. They said, "Go and explore the land." They went into the hill country of Ephraim and got as far as the house of Micah. They camped there for the night.
- 2 So the Danites sent five warriors from Zorah and Eshtaol to spy out the land and explore it. These men represented all their clans. They told them, "Go, explore the land." The men entered the hill country of Ephraim and came to the house of Micah, where they spent the night.
- 3 As they neared Micah's house, they recognized the voice of the young Levite. They went over and said to him, "How on earth did you get here? What's going on? What are you doing here?"
- 3 When they were near Micah's house, they recognized the voice of the young Levite; so they turned in there and asked him, "Who brought you here? What are you doing in this place? Why are you here?"
- 4 He said, "One thing led to another: Micah hired me and I'm now his priest."
- 4 He told them what Micah had done for him, and said, "He has hired me and I am his priest."
- 5 They said, "Oh, good--inquire of God for us. Find out whether our mission will be a success."
- 5 Then they said to him, "Please inquire of God to learn whether our journey will be successful."
- 6 The priest said, "Go assured. GOD's looking out for you all the way."
- 6 The priest answered them, "Go in peace. Your journey has the LORD's approval."
- 7 The five men left and headed north to Laish. They saw that the people there were living in safety under the umbrella of the Sidonians, quiet and unsuspecting. They had everything going for them. But the people lived a long way from the Sidonians to the west and had no treaty with the Arameans to the east.
- 7 So the five men left and came to Laish, where they saw that the people were living in safety, like the Sidonians, unsuspecting and secure. And since their land lacked nothing, they were prosperous. Also, they lived a long way from the Sidonians and had no relationship with anyone else.

- 8 When they got back to Zorah and Eshtaol, their brothers asked, "So, how did you find things?"
- 8 When they returned to Zorah and Eshtaol, their brothers asked them, "How did you find things?"
- 9 They said, "Let's go for it! Let's attack. We've seen the land and it is excellent. Are you going to just sit on your hands? Don't dawdle! Invade and conquer!"
- 9 They answered, "Come on, let's attack them! We have seen that the land is very good. Aren't you going to do something? Don't hesitate to go there and take it over."
- 10 When you get there, you'll find they're sitting ducks, totally unsuspecting. Wide open land--God is handing it over to you, everything you could ever ask for."
- 10 When you get there, you will find an unsuspecting people and a spacious land that God has put into your hands, a land that lacks nothing whatever."
- 11 So 600 Danite men set out from Zorah and Eshtaol, armed to the teeth.
- 11 Then six hundred men from the clan of the Danites, armed for battle, set out from Zorah and Eshtaol.
- 12 Along the way they made camp at Kiriath Jearim in Judah. That is why the place is still today called Dan's Camp--it's just west of Kiriath Jearim.
- 12 On their way they set up camp near Kiriath Jearim in Judah. This is why the place west of Kiriath Jearim is called Mahaneh Dan to this day.
- 13 From there they proceeded into the hill country of Ephraim and came to Micah's house.
- 13 From there they went on to the hill country of Ephraim and came to Micah's house.
- 14 The five men who earlier had explored the country of Laish told their companions, "Did you know there's an ephod, teraphim-idols, and a cast god-sculpture in these buildings? What do you think? Do you want to do something about it?"
- 14 Then the five men who had spied out the land of Laish said to their brothers, "Do you know that one of these houses has an ephod, other household gods, a carved image and a cast idol? Now you know what to do."

- 15 So they turned off the road there, went to the house of the young Levite at Micah's place and asked how things had been with him.
- 15 So they turned in there and went to the house of the young Levite at Micah's place and greeted him.
- 16 The 600 Danites, all well-armed, stood guard at the entrance to the gate
- 16 The six hundred Danites, armed for battle, stood at the entrance to the gate.
- 17 while the five scouts who had gone to explore the land went in and took the carved idol, the ephod, the teraphim-idols, and the god-sculpture. The priest was standing at the gate entrance with the 600 armed men.
- 17 The five men who had spied out the land went inside and took the carved image, the ephod, the other household gods and the cast idol while the priest and the six hundred armed men stood at the entrance to the gate.
- 18 When the five went into Micah's house and took the carved idol, the ephod, the teraphim-idols, and the sculpted god, the priest said to them, "What do you think you're doing?"
- 18 When these men went into Micah's house and took the carved image, the ephod, the other household gods and the cast idol, the priest said to them, "What are you doing?"
- 19 They said to him, "Hush! Don't make a sound. Come with us. Be our father and priest. Which is more important, that you be a priest to one man or that you become priest to a whole tribe and clan in Israel?"
- 19 They answered him, "Be quiet! Don't say a word. Come with us, and be our father and priest. Isn't it better that you serve a tribe and clan in Israel as priest rather than just one man's household?"
- 20 The priest jumped at the chance. He took the ephod, the teraphim-idols, and the idol and fell in with the troops.
- 20 Then the priest was glad. He took the ephod, the other household gods and the carved image and went along with the people.
- 21 They turned away and set out, putting the children, the cattle, and the gear in the lead.
- 21 Putting their little children, their livestock and their possessions in front of them, they turned away and left.
- 22 They were well on their way from Micah's house before Micah and his neighbors got organized. But they soon overtook the Danites.

22 When they had gone some distance from Micah's house, the men who lived near Micah were called together and overtook the Danites.

23 They shouted at them. The Danites turned around and said, "So what's all the noise about?"

23 As they shouted after them, the Danites turned and said to Micah, "What's the matter with you that you called out your men to fight?"

24 Micah said, "You took my god, the one I made, and you took my priest. And you marched off! What do I have left? How can you now say, 'What's the matter?'"

24 He replied, "You took the gods I made, and my priest, and went away. What else do I have? How can you ask, 'What's the matter with you?' "

25 But the Danites answered, "Don't yell at us; you just might provoke some fierce, hot-tempered men to attack you, and you'll end up an army of dead men."

25 The Danites answered, "Don't argue with us, or some hot-tempered men will attack you, and you and your family will lose your lives."

26 The Danites went on their way. Micah saw that he didn't stand a chance against their arms. He turned back and went home.

26 So the Danites went their way, and Micah, seeing that they were too strong for him, turned around and went back home.

27 So they took the things that Micah had made, along with his priest, and they arrived at Laish, that city of quiet and unsuspecting people. They massacred the people and burned down the city.

27 Then they took what Micah had made, and his priest, and went on to Laish, against a peaceful and unsuspecting people. They attacked them with the sword and burned down their city.

28 There was no one around to help. They were a long way from Sidon and had no treaty with the Arameans. Laish was in the valley of Beth Rehob.

28 There was no one to rescue them because they lived a long way from Sidon and had no relationship with anyone else. The city was in a valley near Beth Rehob. The Danites rebuilt the city and settled there.

29 When they rebuilt the city they renamed it Dan after their ancestor who was a son of Israel, but its original name was Laish.

29 They named it Dan after their forefather Dan, who was born to Israel--though the city used to be called Laish.

- 30 The Danites set up the god-figure for themselves. Jonathan son of Gershom, the son of Moses, and his descendants were priests to the tribe of Dan down to the time of the land's captivity.
- 30 There the Danites set up for themselves the idols, and Jonathan son of Gershom, the son of Moses, and his sons were priests for the tribe of Dan until the time of the captivity of the land.
- 31 All during the time that there was a sanctuary of God in Shiloh, they kept for their private use the god-figure that Micah had made.
- 31 They continued to use the idols Micah had made, all the time the house of God was in Shiloh.

Judges 19

MSG

NIV

- 1 It was an era when there was no king in Israel. A Levite, living as a stranger in the backwoods hill country of Ephraim, got himself a concubine, a woman from Bethlehem in Judah.
- 1 In those days Israel had no king. Now a Levite who lived in a remote area in the hill country of Ephraim took a concubine from Bethlehem in Judah.
- 2 But she quarreled with him and left, returning to her father's house in Bethlehem in Judah. She was there four months.
- 2 But she was unfaithful to him. She left him and went back to her father's house in Bethlehem, Judah. After she had been there four months,
- 3 Then her husband decided to go after her and try to win her back. He had a servant and a pair of donkeys with him. When he arrived at her father's house, the girl's father saw him, welcomed him, and made him feel at home.
- 3 her husband went to her to persuade her to return. He had with him his servant and two donkeys. She took him into her father's house, and when her father saw him, he gladly welcomed him.
- 4 His father-in-law, the girl's father, pressed him to stay. He stayed with him three days; they feasted and drank and slept.
- 4 His father-in-law, the girl's father, prevailed upon him to stay; so he remained with him three days, eating and drinking, and sleeping there.

- 5 On the fourth day, they got up at the crack of dawn and got ready to go. But the girl's father said to his son-in-law, "Strengthen yourself with a hearty breakfast and then you can go."
- 5 On the fourth day they got up early and he prepared to leave, but the girl's father said to his son-in-law, "Refresh yourself with something to eat; then you can go."
- 6 So they sat down and ate breakfast together. The girl's father said to the man, "Come now, be my guest. Stay the night--make it a holiday."
- 6 So the two of them sat down to eat and drink together. Afterward the girl's father said, "Please stay tonight and enjoy yourself."
- 7 The man got up to go, but his father-in-law kept after him, so he ended up spending another night.
- 7 And when the man got up to go, his father-in-law persuaded him, so he stayed there that night.
- 8 On the fifth day, he was again up early, ready to go. The girl's father said, "You need some breakfast." They went back and forth, and the day slipped on as they ate and drank together.
- 8 On the morning of the fifth day, when he rose to go, the girl's father said, "Refresh yourself. Wait till afternoon!" So the two of them ate together.
- 9 But the man and his concubine were finally ready to go. Then his father-in-law, the girl's father, said, "Look, the day's almost gone--why not stay the night? There's very little daylight left; stay another night and enjoy yourself. Tomorrow you can get an early start and set off for your own place."
- 9 Then when the man, with his concubine and his servant, got up to leave, his father-in-law, the girl's father, said, "Now look, it's almost evening. Spend the night here; the day is nearly over. Stay and enjoy yourself. Early tomorrow morning you can get up and be on your way home."
- 10 But this time the man wasn't willing to spend another night. He got things ready, left, and went as far as Jebus (Jerusalem) with his pair of saddled donkeys, his concubine, and his servant.
- 10 But, unwilling to stay another night, the man left and went toward Jebus (that is, Jerusalem), with his two saddled donkeys and his concubine.
- 11 At Jebus, though, the day was nearly gone. The servant said to his master, "It's late; let's go into this Jebusite city and spend the night."

- 11 When they were near Jebus and the day was almost gone, the servant said to his master, "Come, let's stop at this city of the Jebusites and spend the night."
- 12 But his master said, "We're not going into any city of foreigners. We'll go on to Gibeah."
- 12 His master replied, "No. We won't go into an alien city, whose people are not Israelites. We will go on to Gibeah."
- 13 He directed his servant, "Keep going. Let's go on ahead. We'll spend the night either at Gibeah or Ramah."
- 13 He added, "Come, let's try to reach Gibeah or Ramah and spend the night in one of those places."
- 14 So they kept going. As they pressed on, the sun finally left them in the vicinity of Gibeah, which belongs to Benjamin.
- 14 So they went on, and the sun set as they neared Gibeah in Benjamin.
- 15 They left the road there to spend the night at Gibeah. The Levite went and sat down in the town square, but no one invited them in to spend the night.
- 15 There they stopped to spend the night. They went and sat in the city square, but no one took them into his home for the night.
- 16 Then, late in the evening, an old man came in from his day's work in the fields. He was from the hill country of Ephraim and lived temporarily in Gibeah where all the local citizens were Benjaminites.
- 16 That evening an old man from the hill country of Ephraim, who was living in Gibeah (the men of the place were Benjamites), came in from his work in the fields.
- 17 When the old man looked up and saw the traveler in the town square, he said, "Where are you going? And where are you from?"
- 17 When he looked and saw the traveler in the city square, the old man asked, "Where are you going? Where did you come from?"
- 18 The Levite said, "We're just passing through. We're coming from Bethlehem on our way to a remote spot in the hills of Ephraim. I come from there. I've just made a trip to Bethlehem in Judah and I'm on my way back home, but no one has invited us in for the night.
- 18 He answered, "We are on our way from Bethlehem in Judah to a remote area in the hill country of Ephraim where I live. I have been to

Bethlehem in Judah and now I am going to the house of the LORD. No one has taken me into his house.

19 We wouldn't be any trouble: We have food and straw for the donkeys, and bread and wine for the woman, the young man, and me--we don't need anything."

19 We have both straw and fodder for our donkeys and bread and wine for ourselves your servants--me, your maidservant, and the young man with us. We don't need anything."

20 The old man said, "It's going to be all right; I'll take care of you. You aren't going to spend the night in the town square."

20 You are welcome at my house, the old man said. "Let me supply whatever you need. Only don't spend the night in the square."

21 He took them home and fed the donkeys. They washed up and sat down to a good meal.

21 So he took him into his house and fed his donkeys. After they had washed their feet, they had something to eat and drink.

22 They were relaxed and enjoying themselves when the men of the city, a gang of local hell-raisers all, surrounded the house and started pounding on the door. They yelled for the owner of the house, the old man, "Bring out the man who came to your house. We want to have sex with him."

22 While they were enjoying themselves, some of the wicked men of the city surrounded the house. Pounding on the door, they shouted to the old man who owned the house, "Bring out the man who came to your house so we can have sex with him."

23 He went out and told them, "No, brothers! Don't be obscene--this man is my guest. Don't commit this outrage.

23 The owner of the house went outside and said to them, "No, my friends, don't be so vile. Since this man is my guest, don't do this disgraceful thing.

24 Look, my virgin daughter and his concubine are here. I'll bring them out for you. Abuse them if you must, but don't do anything so senselessly vile to this man."

24 Look, here is my virgin daughter, and his concubine. I will bring them out to you now, and you can use them and do to them whatever you wish. But to this man, don't do such a disgraceful thing."

- 25 But the men wouldn't listen to him. Finally, the Levite pushed his concubine out the door to them. They raped her repeatedly all night long. Just before dawn they let her go.
- 25 But the men would not listen to him. So the man took his concubine and sent her outside to them, and they raped her and abused her throughout the night, and at dawn they let her go.
- 26 The woman came back and fell at the door of the house where her master was sleeping. When the sun rose, there she was.
- 26 At daybreak the woman went back to the house where her master was staying, fell down at the door and lay there until daylight.
- 27 It was morning. Her master got up and opened the door to continue his journey. There she was, his concubine, crumpled in a heap at the door, her hands on the threshold.
- 27 When her master got up in the morning and opened the door of the house and stepped out to continue on his way, there lay his concubine, fallen in the doorway of the house, with her hands on the threshold.
- 28 "Get up," he said. "Let's get going." There was no answer.
- 28 He said to her, "Get up; let's go." But there was no answer. Then the man put her on his donkey and set out for home.
- 29 He lifted her onto his donkey and set out for home. When he got home he took a knife and dismembered his concubine--cut her into twelve pieces. He sent her, piece by piece, throughout the country of Israel.
- 29 When he reached home, he took a knife and cut up his concubine, limb by limb, into twelve parts and sent them into all the areas of Israel.
- 30 And he ordered the men he sent out, "Say to every man in Israel: 'Has such a thing as this ever happened from the time the Israelites came up from the land of Egypt until now? Think about it! Talk it over. Do something!'"
- 30 Everyone who saw it said, "Such a thing has never been seen or done, not since the day the Israelites came up out of Egypt. Think about it! Consider it! Tell us what to do!"

Judges 20

MSG

NIV

- 1 Then all the People of Israel came out. The congregation met in the presence of GOD at Mizpah. They were all there, from Dan to Beersheba, as one person!
- 1 Then all the Israelites from Dan to Beersheba and from the land of Gilead came out as one man and assembled before the LORD in Mizpah.
- 2 The leaders of all the people, representing all the tribes of Israel, took their places in the gathering of God's people. There were 400 divisions of sword-wielding infantry.
- 2 The leaders of all the people of the tribes of Israel took their places in the assembly of the people of God, four hundred thousand soldiers armed with swords.
- 3 Meanwhile the Benjaminites got wind that the Israelites were meeting at Mizpah. The People of Israel said, "Now tell us. How did this outrageous evil happen?"
- 3 (The Benjaminites heard that the Israelites had gone up to Mizpah.) Then the Israelites said, "Tell us how this awful thing happened."
- 4 The Levite, the husband of the murdered woman, spoke: "My concubine and I came to spend the night at Gibeah, a Benjaminite town.
- 4 So the Levite, the husband of the murdered woman, said, "I and my concubine came to Gibeah in Benjamin to spend the night.
- 5 That night the men of Gibeah came after me. They surrounded the house, intending to kill me. They gang-raped my concubine and she died.
- 5 During the night the men of Gibeah came after me and surrounded the house, intending to kill me. They raped my concubine, and she died.
- 6 So I took my concubine, cut up her body, and sent her piece by piece--twelve pieces!--to every part of Israel's inheritance. This vile and outrageous crime was committed in Israel!
- 6 I took my concubine, cut her into pieces and sent one piece to each region of Israel's inheritance, because they committed this lewd and disgraceful act in Israel.
- 7 So, Israelites, make up your minds. Decide on some action!"
- 7 Now, all you Israelites, speak up and give your verdict."
- 8 All the people were at once and as one person on their feet. "None of us will go home; not a single one of us will go to his own house.
- 8 All the people rose as one man, saying, "None of us will go home. No, not one of us will return to his house.

- 9 Here's our plan for dealing with Gibeah: We'll march against it by drawing lots.
- 9 But now this is what we'll do to Gibeah: We'll go up against it as the lot directs.
- 10 We'll take ten of every hundred men from all the tribes of Israel (a hundred of every thousand, and a thousand of every ten thousand) to carry food for the army. When the troops arrive at Gibeah they will settle accounts for this outrageous and vile evil that was done in Israel."
- 10 We'll take ten men out of every hundred from all the tribes of Israel, and a hundred from a thousand, and a thousand from ten thousand, to get provisions for the army. Then, when the army arrives at Gibeah in Benjamin, it can give them what they deserve for all this vileness done in Israel."
- 11 So all the men in Israel were gathered against the city, totally united.
- 11 So all the men of Israel got together and united as one man against the city.
- 12 The Israelite tribes sent messengers throughout the tribe of Benjamin saying, "What's the meaning of this outrage that took place among you?"
- 12 The tribes of Israel sent men throughout the tribe of Benjamin, saying, "What about this awful crime that was committed among you?"
- 13 Surrender the men right here and now, these hell-raisers of Gibeah. We'll put them to death and burn the evil out of Israel." But they wouldn't do it. The Benjaminites refused to listen to their brothers, the People of Israel.
- 13 Now surrender those wicked men of Gibeah so that we may put them to death and purge the evil from Israel." But the Benjaminites would not listen to their fellow Israelites.
- 14 Instead they raised an army from all their cities and rallied at Gibeah to go to war against the People of Israel.
- 14 From their towns they came together at Gibeah to fight against the Israelites.
- 15 In no time at all they had recruited from their cities twenty-six divisions of sword-wielding infantry. From Gibeah they got 700 hand-picked fighters, the best.
- 15 At once the Benjaminites mobilized twenty-six thousand swordsmen from their towns, in addition to seven hundred chosen men from those living

in Gibeah.

16 There were another 700 super marksmen who were ambidextrous--they could sling a stone at a hair and not miss.

16 Among all these soldiers there were seven hundred chosen men who were left-handed, each of whom could sling a stone at a hair and not miss.

17 The men of Israel, excluding Benjamin, mobilized 400 divisions of sword-wielding fighting men.

17 Israel, apart from Benjamin, mustered four hundred thousand swordsmen, all of them fighting men.

18 They set out and went to Bethel to inquire of God. The People of Israel said, "Who of us shall be first to go into battle with the Benjaminites?" GOD said, "Judah goes first."

18 The Israelites went up to Bethel and inquired of God. They said, "Who of us shall go first to fight against the Benjaminites?" The LORD replied, "Judah shall go first."

19 The People of Israel got up the next morning and camped before Gibeah.

19 The next morning the Israelites got up and pitched camp near Gibeah.

20 The army of Israel marched out against Benjamin and took up their positions, ready to attack Gibeah.

20 The men of Israel went out to fight the Benjaminites and took up battle positions against them at Gibeah.

21 But the Benjaminites poured out of Gibeah and devastated twenty-two Israelite divisions on the ground.

21 The Benjaminites came out of Gibeah and cut down twenty-two thousand Israelites on the battlefield that day.

22 The army took heart. The men of Israel took up the positions they had deployed on the first day.

22 But the men of Israel encouraged one another and again took up their positions where they had stationed themselves the first day.

23 The Israelites went back to the sanctuary and wept before GOD until evening. They again inquired of GOD, "Shall we again go into battle against the Benjaminites, our brothers?" GOD said, "Yes. Attack."

23 The Israelites went up and wept before the LORD until evening, and they inquired of the LORD. They said, "Shall we go up again to battle

against the Benjamites, our brothers?" The LORD answered, "Go up against them."

24 On the second day, the Israelites again advanced against Benjamin.

24 Then the Israelites drew near to Benjamin the second day.

25 This time as the Benjaminites came out of the city, on this second day, they devastated another eighteen Israelite divisions, all swordsmen.

25 This time, when the Benjamites came out from Gibeah to oppose them, they cut down another eighteen thousand Israelites, all of them armed with swords.

26 All the People of Israel, the whole army, were back at Bethel, weeping, sitting there in the presence of GOD. That day they fasted until evening. They sacrificed Whole-Burnt-Offerings and Peace-Offerings before GOD.

26 Then the Israelites, all the people, went up to Bethel, and there they sat weeping before the LORD. They fasted that day until evening and presented burnt offerings and fellowship offerings to the LORD.

27 And they again inquired of GOD. The Chest of God's Covenant was there at that time with

27 And the Israelites inquired of the LORD. (In those days the ark of the covenant of God was there,

28 Phinehas son of Eleazar, the son of Aaron, as the ministering priest. They asked, "Shall we again march into battle against the Benjaminites, our brothers? Or should we call it quits?" And GOD said, "Attack. Tomorrow I'll give you victory."

28 with Phinehas son of Eleazar, the son of Aaron, ministering before it.) They asked, "Shall we go up again to battle with Benjamin our brother, or not?" The LORD responded, "Go, for tomorrow I will give them into your hands."

29 This time Israel placed men in ambush all around Gibeah.

29 Then Israel set an ambush around Gibeah.

30 On the third day when Israel set out, they took up the same positions before the Benjaminites as before.

30 They went up against the Benjamites on the third day and took up positions against Gibeah as they had done before.

31 When the Benjaminites came out to meet the army, they moved out from the city. Benjaminites began to cut down some of the troops just as

they had before. About thirty men fell in the field and on the roads to Bethel and Gibeah.

31 The Benjamites came out to meet them and were drawn away from the city. They began to inflict casualties on the Israelites as before, so that about thirty men fell in the open field and on the roads--the one leading to Bethel and the other to Gibeah.

32 The Benjaminites started bragging, "We're dropping them like flies, just as before!"

32 While the Benjamites were saying, "We are defeating them as before," the Israelites were saying, "Let's retreat and draw them away from the city to the roads."

33 But the Israelites strategized: "Now let's retreat and pull them out of the city onto the main roads." So every Israelite moved farther out to Baal Tamar; at the same time the Israelite ambush rushed from its place west of Gibeah.

33 All the men of Israel moved from their places and took up positions at Baal Tamar, and the Israelite ambush charged out of its place on the west of Gibeah.

34 Ten crack divisions from all over Israel now arrived at Gibeah--intense, bloody fighting! The Benjaminites had no idea that they were about to go down in defeat--

34 Then ten thousand of Israel's finest men made a frontal attack on Gibeah. The fighting was so heavy that the Benjamites did not realize how near disaster was.

35 GOD routed them before Israel. The Israelites decimated twenty-five divisions of Benjamin that day--25,100 killed. They were all swordsmen.

35 The LORD defeated Benjamin before Israel, and on that day the Israelites struck down 25,100 Benjamites, all armed with swords.

36 The Benjaminites saw that they were beaten. The men of Israel acted like they were retreating before Benjamin, knowing that they could depend on the ambush they had prepared for Gibeah.

36 Then the Benjamites saw that they were beaten. Now the men of Israel had given way before Benjamin, because they relied on the ambush they had set near Gibeah.

37 The ambush erupted and made quick work of Gibeah. The ambush spread out and massacred the city.

- 37 The men who had been in ambush made a sudden dash into Gibeah, spread out and put the whole city to the sword.
- 38 The strategy for the main body of the ambush was that they send up a smoke signal from the city.
- 38 The men of Israel had arranged with the ambush that they should send up a great cloud of smoke from the city,
- 39 Then the men of Israel would turn in battle. When that happened, Benjamin had killed about thirty Israelites and thought they were on their way to victory, yelling out, "They're on the run, just as in the first battle!"
- 39 and then the men of Israel would turn in the battle. The Benjamites had begun to inflict casualties on the men of Israel (about thirty), and they said, "We are defeating them as in the first battle."
- 40 But then the signal went up from the city--a huge column of smoke. When the Benjaminites looked back, there it was, the whole city going up in smoke.
- 40 But when the column of smoke began to rise from the city, the Benjamites turned and saw the smoke of the whole city going up into the sky.
- 41 By the time the men of Israel had turned back on them, the men of Benjamin fell apart--they could see that they were trapped.
- 41 Then the men of Israel turned on them, and the men of Benjamin were terrified, because they realized that disaster had come upon them.
- 42 Confronted by the Israelites, they tried to get away down the wilderness road, but by now the battle was everywhere. The men of Israel poured out of the towns, killing them right and left,
- 42 So they fled before the Israelites in the direction of the desert, but they could not escape the battle. And the men of Israel who came out of the towns cut them down there.
- 43 hot on their trail, picking them off east of Gibeah.
- 43 They surrounded the Benjamites, chased them and easily overran them in the vicinity of Gibeah on the east.
- 44 Eighteen divisions of Benjaminites were wiped out, all their best fighters.
- 44 Eighteen thousand Benjamites fell, all of them valiant fighters.

- 45 Five divisions turned to escape to the wilderness, to Rimmon Rock, but the Israelites caught and slaughtered them on roads. Keeping the pressure on, the Israelites brought down two more divisions.
- 45 As they turned and fled toward the desert to the rock of Rimmon, the Israelites cut down five thousand men along the roads. They kept pressing after the Benjamites as far as Gidom and struck down two thousand more.
- 46 The total of the Benjaminites killed that day came to twenty-five divisions of infantry, their best swordsmen.
- 46 On that day twenty-five thousand Benjamite swordsmen fell, all of them valiant fighters.
- 47 Six hundred men got away. They made it to Rimmon Rock in the wilderness and held out there for four months.
- 47 But six hundred men turned and fled into the desert to the rock of Rimmon, where they stayed four months.
- 48 The men of Israel came back and killed all the Benjaminites who were left, all the men and animals they found in every town, and then torched the towns, sending them up in flames.
- 48 The men of Israel went back to Benjamin and put all the towns to the sword, including the animals and everything else they found. All the towns they came across they set on fire.

Judges 21

MSG

NIV

- 1 Back at Mizpah the men of Israel had taken an oath: "No man among us will give his daughter to a Benjaminite in marriage."
- 1 The men of Israel had taken an oath at Mizpah: "Not one of us will give his daughter in marriage to a Benjamite."
- 2 Now, back in Bethel, the people sat in the presence of God until evening. They cried loudly; there was widespread lamentation.
- 2 The people went to Bethel, where they sat before God until evening, raising their voices and weeping bitterly.
- 3 They said, "Why, O GOD, God of Israel, has this happened? Why do we find ourselves today missing one whole tribe from Israel?"

- 3 O LORD, the God of Israel, they cried, "why has this happened to Israel? Why should one tribe be missing from Israel today?"
- 4 Early the next morning, the people got busy and built an altar. They sacrificed Whole-Burnt-Offerings and Peace-Offerings.
- 4 Early the next day the people built an altar and presented burnt offerings and fellowship offerings.
- 5 Then the Israelites said, "Who from all the tribes of Israel didn't show up as we gathered in the presence of GOD?" For they had all taken a sacred oath that anyone who had not gathered in the presence of GOD at Mizpah had to be put to death.
- 5 Then the Israelites asked, "Who from all the tribes of Israel has failed to assemble before the LORD?" For they had taken a solemn oath that anyone who failed to assemble before the LORD at Mizpah should certainly be put to death.
- 6 But the People of Israel were feeling sorry for Benjamin, their brothers. They said, "Today, one tribe is cut off from Israel.
- 6 Now the Israelites grieved for their brothers, the Benjamites. "Today one tribe is cut off from Israel," they said.
- 7 How can we get wives for those who are left? We have sworn by GOD not to give any of our daughters to them in marriage."
- 7 How can we provide wives for those who are left, since we have taken an oath by the LORD not to give them any of our daughters in marriage?
- 8 They said, "Which one of the tribes of Israel didn't gather before GOD at Mizpah?" It turned out that no one had come to the gathering from Jabesh Gilead.
- 8 Then they asked, "Which one of the tribes of Israel failed to assemble before the LORD at Mizpah?" They discovered that no one from Jabesh Gilead had come to the camp for the assembly.
- 9 When they took a roll call of the people, not a single person from Jabesh Gilead was there.
- 9 For when they counted the people, they found that none of the people of Jabesh Gilead were there.
- 10 So the congregation sent twelve divisions of their top men there with the command, "Kill everyone of Jabesh Gilead, including women and children.

- 10 So the assembly sent twelve thousand fighting men with instructions to go to Jabesh Gilead and put to the sword those living there, including the women and children.
- 11 These are your instructions: Every man and woman who has had sexual intercourse you must kill. But keep the virgins alive." And that's what they did.
- 11 This is what you are to do, they said. "Kill every male and every woman who is not a virgin."
- 12 And they found 400 virgins among those who lived in Jabesh Gilead; they had never had sexual intercourse with a man. And they brought them to the camp at Shiloh, which is in the land of Canaan.
- 12 They found among the people living in Jabesh Gilead four hundred young women who had never slept with a man, and they took them to the camp at Shiloh in Canaan.
- 13 Then the congregation sent word to the Benjaminites who were at the Rimmon Rock and offered them peace.
- 13 Then the whole assembly sent an offer of peace to the Benjamites at the rock of Rimmon.
- 14 And Benjamin came. They gave them the women they had let live at Jabesh Gilead. But even then, there weren't enough for all the men.
- 14 So the Benjamites returned at that time and were given the women of Jabesh Gilead who had been spared. But there were not enough for all of them.
- 15 The people felt bad for Benjamin; GOD had left out Benjamin--the missing piece from the Israelite tribes.
- 15 The people grieved for Benjamin, because the LORD had made a gap in the tribes of Israel.
- 16 The elders of the congregation said, "How can we get wives for the rest of the men, since all the Benjaminite women have been killed?"
- 16 And the elders of the assembly said, "With the women of Benjamin destroyed, how shall we provide wives for the men who are left?"
- 17 How can we keep the inheritance alive for the Benjaminite survivors? How can we prevent an entire tribe from extinction?
- 17 The Benjamite survivors must have heirs," they said, "so that a tribe of Israel will not be wiped out."

- 18 We certainly can't give our own daughters to them as wives."
(Remember, the Israelites had taken the oath: "Cursed is anyone who provides a wife to Benjamin.")
- 18 We can't give them our daughters as wives, since we Israelites have taken this oath: 'Cursed be anyone who gives a wife to a Benjamite.'
- 19 Then they said, "There is that festival of GOD held every year in Shiloh. It's north of Bethel, just east of the main road that goes up from Bethel to Shechem and a little south of Lebonah."
- 19 But look, there is the annual festival of the LORD in Shiloh, to the north of Bethel, and east of the road that goes from Bethel to Shechem, and to the south of Lebonah."
- 20 So they told the Benjaminites, "Go and hide in the vineyards.
- 20 So they instructed the Benjamites, saying, "Go and hide in the vineyards
- 21 Stay alert--when you see the Shiloh girls come out to dance the dances, run out of the vineyards, grab one of the Shiloh girls for your wife, and then hightail it back to the country of Benjamin.
- 21 and watch. When the girls of Shiloh come out to join in the dancing, then rush from the vineyards and each of you seize a wife from the girls of Shiloh and go to the land of Benjamin.
- 22 When their fathers or brothers come to lay charges against us, we'll tell them, 'We did them a favor. After all we didn't go to war and kill to get wives for men. And it wasn't as if you were in on it by giving consent. But if you keep this up, you will incur blame.'"
- 22 When their fathers or brothers complain to us, we will say to them, 'Do us a kindness by helping them, because we did not get wives for them during the war, and you are innocent, since you did not give your daughters to them.' "
- 23 And that's what the Benjaminites did: They carried off girls from the dance, wives enough for their number, got away, and went home to their inheritance. They rebuilt their towns and settled down.
- 23 So that is what the Benjamites did. While the girls were dancing, each man caught one and carried her off to be his wife. Then they returned to their inheritance and rebuilt the towns and settled in them.
- 24 From there the People of Israel dispersed, each man heading back to his own tribe and clan, each to his own plot of land.

- 24 At that time the Israelites left that place and went home to their tribes and clans, each to his own inheritance.
- 25 At that time there was no king in Israel. People did whatever they felt like doing.
- 25 In those days Israel had no king; everyone did as he saw fit.